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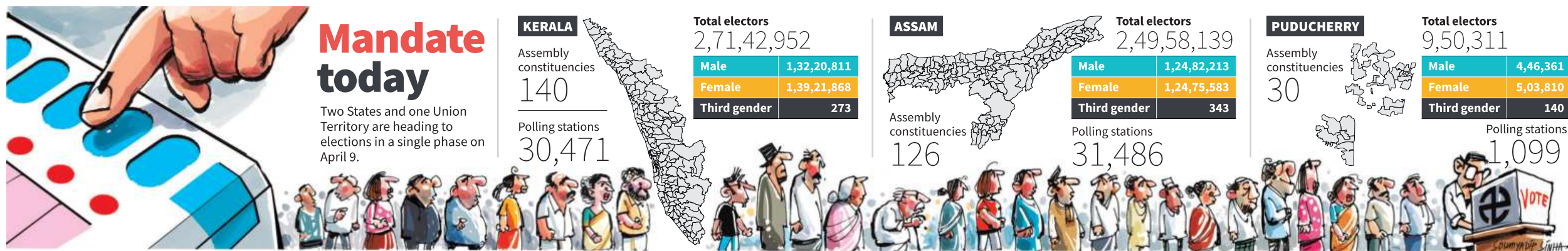
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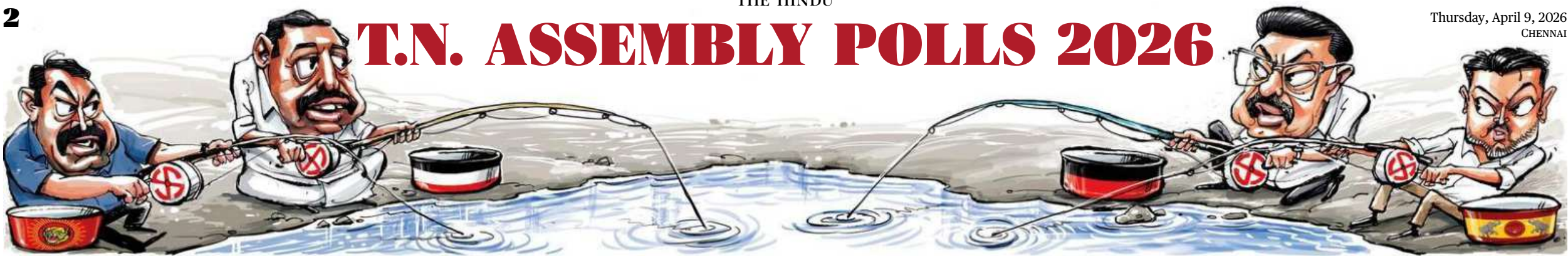


Based on CBRE report 2024

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Well tweaked: The software for the randomisation of polling personnel is customised in such a manner that it will allocate their own Assembly constituency to the women personnel to the maximum extent possible during the second randomisation process. FILE PHOTO

ECI fine-tunes its strategy to fit in the ground reality

Dennis S. Jesudasan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu has more women electors than men, and the political parties in the State have long vied with one another for announcing welfare schemes designed for the benefit of women. The Election Commission of India, too, is adapting itself to a similar reality. It has modified some of its procedures to suit the scenario in Tamil Nadu.

Negative list

The Election Commission has decided to continue with the system of computer-based randomisation but has directed authorities to prepare a ‘negative list’ of polling stations (considered inaccessible or remotely located) where no women personnel will be posted. Earlier, women polling workers were deployed only through manual randomisation.

However, to ensure the safety of women personnel, Tamil Nadu Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Archana Patnaik has requested the District Election Officers (DEOs) to make available basic facilities, including transport, during the deployment of the personnel. “The software for the randomisation of polling personnel will allocate the same Assembly constituency for the women polling personnel to the maximum possible extent.”

No computer randomisation

Originally, the ‘SOP for Last 72 Hours’, published by the Election Commission in 2023, says the women personnel should not be deployed on the basis of computer randomisation. It further said they should be deployed through manual randomisation so that they could go to the polling booths on the morning of polling day.

After the schedule for the Tamil Nadu Assembly election was issued on March 15 this year, Ms. Archana Patnaik brought the situation to the notice of the Election Commission on March 18.

She said, “In this State [Tamil Nadu], more than 60% of the polling personnel are in the women category.” If about two lakh women

personnel were to be deployed by manual randomisation, “it will be a cumbersome activity for the District Election Officers,” she said.

The officer further said the software for the randomisation of the polling personnel was now customised by Tamil Nadu in such a manner that it would allocate the same Assembly constituency (where the women personnel were residing) to the personnel to the maximum extent possible during the second randomisation process.

During the third randomisation process, based on availability, the software would try to allocate the nearby polling booths opted by the women personnel for the entire team.

Proposal approved

The Election Commission of India has approved Ms. Patnaik’s proposal and she has informed the District Election Officers that the software for randomisation will allocate the same constituency to the maximum extent possible.

T.N. ASSEMBLY POLLS 2026

Udhayanidhi strikes a chord with the voters on campaign trail at Egmore

The Deputy Chief Minister, who started his campaign in Tiruvallur and Avadi on Wednesday, visited other constituencies before reaching Purasawalkam. He listed development projects implemented in Egmore, including TNUHDB tenements at Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

Thana Street, nestled in the bustling market hub of Purasawalkam, was busier on Wednesday as the campaign trail rolled through the stretch, drawing shoppers, traders, and cheering cadre, and residents to the roadside.

The rhythmic *chenda melam* filled the street well before the arrival of Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin, lending the trail a festive air as the crowd began to swell. Colourful flags and placards bearing the symbols of the DMK and its allies dotted the street, turning the stretch into a vibrant campaign corridor. As the crowd waited, a light music band took over, performing political songs set to popular film tunes that kept the energy alive and ensured that people stayed despite the oppressive, sultry evening weather. Announcements were made at regular intervals, cautioning the people to stay safe. Chennai Mayor R. Priya and DMK candidate for Egmore S. Prasanna, popularly called *Tamilan Prasanna*, arrived earlier at the site and clicked pictures with the cadre and



Walking extra mile: Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin seeking votes for DMK candidate for Egmore *Tamilan Prasanna* at Purasawalkam in Chennai on Wednesday. M. SRINATH

residents and sought votes.

Mr. Udhayanadhi, who started his campaign in the Tiruvallur and Avadi constituencies on Wednesday, also visited other constituencies, including the star constituency of Kolathur and Villivakkam, before reaching Purasawalkam.

Blending a conversational tone with crisp messages, he has been striking a chord with the cadre and residents on the campaign trail. Steering away from long, rhetoric speeches in chaste Tamil, he opted for a direct interaction with

voters, tinged with humour and delivered in colloquial Tamil.

Loud responses

Mr. Udhayanidhi’s speech, punctuated with pauses and direct questions, drew quick and loud responses from those gathered on the street. As he began in his usual warm tone with “*Nalla irukeengala?*” (How are you?) and greeted women voters, the crowd erupted in cheers and answered his questions in chorus.

Pointing out that the Eg-

more DMK candidate won by 40,000 votes in the previous election, he appealed to the cadre and residents to help Mr. Prasanna win by a minimum of 50,000 votes this time. Mr. Udhayanidhi told the crowd that he had made it a point to visit the constituency, though he was unwell and advised rest by doctors. Amid a whirlwind 10-day campaign tour of more than 40 constituencies, he reached Egmore, his 45th stop. In a light-hearted moment, he asked the people if they

DMK stands with the people every day and not just during election. Udhayanidhi said, highlighting the government’s welfare measures for various sections of society

were aware that he was also in the fray this time, prompting cheers and answers in the affirmative.

Introducing the candidate, he said, “My presence here matters more. I regard victory in Egmore as more important than my victory.” Just like every other stop where his speeches touch the local civic issues, he listed development works implemented in Egmore, including TNUHDB tenements at Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar, renovation of Connemara Public Library, Vadachenai Valarchi Thittam, a new hockey turf at Mayor Radhakrishnan Stadium, and the eco-park at Chetpet.

“The DMK stands with the people every day and not just during election,” said Mr. Udhayanidhi, who highlighted the DMK government’s welfare measures for various sections, including free bus travel for women, the Chief Mi-

nister’s Breakfast Scheme, and *Kalaingar Magalir Urimai Thogai* (the monthly financial assistance to women). Even as his speech was centred on the DMK government’s record in public welfare with a strong pitch to women and youngsters promising an expansion of benefits, including an ₹8,000 coupon for eligible home-makers, he did not forget to launch pointed attacks on the Opposition.

‘Protect our rights’

He asked the residents to use their votes to protect Tamil Nadu’s rights. Mr. Udhayanidhi, who had earlier gained traction for his ‘AIIMS brick’ remarks that underscored his criticism of the Centre over delayed projects, held up a picture of AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami to portray him as being subservient to Delhi. Even as crowd broke into chants of “Show the photo, show the photo”, he said Mr. Palaniswami had launched a scathing attack on him and used the moment to sharpen his criticism of the Opposition party. He ended his speech with an appeal not to allow what he described as a “subservient Opposition” party to come to power.

Oppressive weather adds to the election heat this season

Zubeda Hamid
CHENNAI

Eighty-year-old R. Chandrasekaran is, like many across Tamil Nadu, looking forward to casting his vote in the April 23 Assembly election. In fact, Dr. Chandrasekaran, president of the Raja Annamalaipuram Residents’ Association, has been encouraging all residents of the locality to go out and vote. The only daunting factor here is not age but the heat. Dr. Chandrasekaran says he is advising residents to hydrate adequately before setting out, and carry a bottle of water.

More heatwave days

This year, the India Meteorological Department has warned, many parts of the country will experience an “above-normal” number of heatwave days in the period between April and June.

The Regional Meteorological Centre has issued a heat index advisory for the State, especially the coastal areas. The trough prevailing over the Tamil Nadu region is to lead to moisture incursion and a rise in the humidity level, and the combination of humid air and high temperatures will influence hot weather and discomfort for residents in places like Chennai. Extreme heat, especially combined with high humidity, can be detrimental to the human body, with certain segments of the population particularly at risk – older adults, individuals with chronic illnesses, and outdoor workers, among them.

Mercury rising

The India Meteorological Department has warned that this year, many parts of the country will experience an “above normal” number of heatwave days between April and June. Polling officials and party workers need to be sensitised to the fact that extreme heat can be fatal



Sweating it out: Political party workers during the election campaign in peak summer in Tiruchi. M. MOORTHY

Polling officials need to be sensitised to the fact that extreme heat can be fatal, notes Mahaveer Golechha, professor of public health, Indian Institute of Public Health-Gandhinagar.

He points to the need to create awareness of how to be ‘heat safe’: learning how to identify symptoms, taking precautions, ensuring first aid is available, and keeping a supply of oral rehydration salts (ORS) at all times. “Capacity-building and training is crucial,” he adds, recalling the tragic death of over 30 poll workers in a single day in Uttar Pradesh during the 2024 election.

For candidates and party workers, the heat makes it difficult to visit constituencies between 11 a.m. and 4 p.m. Campaigns

scheduled to start in the afternoon are being pushed to the evening due to the heat. Thousand Lights MLA and DMK candidate N. Ezhilan says he begins his door-to-door campaign every day at 7.30 a.m. and concludes it by 10.30 a.m. He resumes campaigning at 4.30 p.m. and continues until 9.30 p.m. “As a doctor, I ensure that those accompanying me remain well hydrated, particularly the elderly who are vulnerable to heat-related illnesses in humid conditions. I advise them to drink water or take ORS,” he says.

Voter factors

Voters may run into extreme heat at political rallies they participate in or watch, and on the day of voting itself. Again, creating awareness of heat-relat-

ed illnesses and what to watch out for are important, says Dr. Golechha.

On polling day, says Chirag Dhara, climate and sustainability scientist at Krea University, intense heat could affect specific demographics among voters. “While it is difficult to make a direct connection between extreme heat and the impact on voter representation, due to the complexities involved and the lack of localised heat-related morbidity data to isolate these effects, what we do know is that elderly citizens and people particularly susceptible to heat such as those with heart, lung, or kidney diseases may be the most affected,” he notes.

(With inputs from N. Sai Charan, K. Lakshmi, and Aloysius Xavier Lopez.)

Dalit Women’s Rights Manifesto seeks quota in governance

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

An internal reservation policy should be enacted to ensure the representation of Dalit women in governance, including in the local bodies and the State Legislative Assembly, according to the Dalit Women’s Rights and Financial Independence Manifesto, 2026. The manifesto was brought out by former IAS officer and writer P. Sivakami on behalf of the All India Forum for Women Intellect. It stresses the need to transform Dalit women into producers in the workforce.

‘Panchami’ land

The manifesto points out that a high-powered land recovery commission should be established to recover ‘panchami’ land within 100 days of government formation and redistribute the land to the landless Dalit women. Priority must be given to homeless women in Dalit settlements in the allotment of individual apartments or concrete houses.

“Training in various fields should be given to women – and not just freebies – to promote economic freedom,” Ms. Sivakami said. Noting that economic empowerment is crucial for women, the manifesto stated that a dedicated government bank for Dalit women must be established to provide collateral-free and interest-free loans for starting small businesses.

“Every Dalit settlement

The manifesto stresses the need to transform Dalit women into producers in the workforce

must be transformed into an ‘agro-industry hub’, where factories for making value-added products will be established. A 25% priority quota will be provided to Dalit women in land allotment by government industrial bodies,” the manifesto said.

It added that free digital vouchers must be given to Dalit students to undergo training in AI, coding, and data science. “Wage discrimination against Dalit women in the farming and construction sectors should be abolished, and equal pay legally guaranteed,” the manifesto said.

Protection force

It stated that free training and heavy vehicle licences for cars, vans, trucks, and tractors must be given to one lakh Dalit women. Dalit women protection unit, a special protection force led by women IPS officers, must be constituted at the district level to prevent crimes against Dalit women. “Special courts should be mandated to complete cases filed under the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act within six months. The government must also pay legal fees to victims to hire lawyers of their choice,” the manifesto added.

INBRIEF



Students paint their face to boost young voter turnout

Students of Sri Kanyaka Parameswari Arts and Science College for Women enthusiastically took part in a face painting activity to encourage young voters to actively participate in the upcoming Assembly election, said a press release. They painted creative designs and impactful slogans on their faces, conveying strong messages such as “Every vote counts,” “Your vote, your voice,” and “Be a responsible citizen.” The event aimed to educate young voters about their democratic responsibility, and encourage their active participation in the election.

Police arrest accused in Villivakkam murder case

The city police have arrested an absconding accused against whom a court warrant was pending in a 2014 murder case registered at the Villivakkam police station. The police said the case relates to the murder of Nagaraj in Villivakkam. The accused, including Sathesh alias Yugalingam, were initially arrested and remanded to judicial custody. However, Sathesh failed to appear for trial before the 20th Additional Sessions Court at the Allikulam court complex and kept absconding after he was released on bail. Based on this, the court issued a non-bailable warrant against him on October 27 last year. Following directions from the Greater Chennai City Police Commissioner to prioritise the execution of pending warrants, a team led by the Villivakkam police intensified the search. After searches at multiple locations, the police arrested Sathesh, 31, a resident of Villivakkam, on Tuesday. He was produced before the court and remanded to judicial custody.

Superintendent and Inspector of GST Ranipet range arrested by CBI for demanding bribe

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) arrested a Superintendent and an Inspector of Goods and Services Tax (GST) in a bribery case.

The CBI registered the case on Tuesday against the Superintendent of GST, Ranipet range, based on a complaint alleging bribery. The complainant alleged that the Superintendent demanded ₹30,000 as a bribe for providing un-

due advantage and facilitating the clearance of GST registration. After negotiation, the Superintendent agreed to accept a bribe of ₹15,000. Based on the complaint, the CBI officials laid a trap and caught the Superinten-

dent. Meanwhile, the Inspector, the other accused, had concealed the amount in a toilet. The amount was subsequently recovered, and both were arrested. Further investigation is under way.

Free eye camp conducted in city

CHENNAI: Balakrishna Eye Hospital, Saidapet, in association with Jana Seva Trust conducted a free eye camp recently. A total of 65 patients attended the camp and 12 were selected for free eye surgery at the eye hospital.

Timings
CHENNAI

THURSDAY, APR. 09		
RISE	06:01	SET 18:21
RISE	00:00	SET 11:11
FRIDAY, APR. 10		
RISE	06:00	SET 18:21
RISE	00:33	SET 12:04
SATURDAY, APR. 11		
RISE	05:59	SET 18:21
RISE	01:20	SET 12:57

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	35	27
Chennai Airport	34	29
Chennai City	32	29

Chennai Airport Today
36°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm. Night will also be comfortable. Chances of light rain and thundershowers.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
36°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable.

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MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy, Madras Today: From 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall – Young Talented Musician – E.R. Anirudh (Vocal), R. Srikriti (Violin), Sannath Parameswaran (Mridangam) – Programme under the endowment Instituted by Shri K Vivekanandan in memory of his grandfather Sangita Kalanidhi Dr. Semmangudi R Srinivasa Iyer.

Arulmigu Sri Kapaleeswarar Temple, Mylapore, Chennai Panguni Peruvizha and Vidai-aatri Music and Dance Festival. Today 09-04-2026 Thursday 6:30pm, Akkarai Sisters Smt S Subhalakshmi & Kum S Sornalatha - Vocal, Thanjavur Sri.Tv Govindarajan - Thavil, Sri.Hn Baskar Violin, Sri B Shree Sundar Kumar - Mridangam. Tomorrow 10-04-2026 Friday 6:30 pm, Smt Ranjani & Smt Gayathri - Vocal, Smt Charumathi Raghuram - Violin, Sri Manoj Siva - Mridangam, Sri Krishna - Ghatam. All Are Welcome.

NIYANTRI (9444334753) Presents SOUND OF LIGHT @ MS SUBBULAKSHMI ARANGAM, ASIAN COLLEGE OF JOURNALISM, THARAMANI April 11th, 6 PM A talk and performance celebrating the launch of NIYANTRI - a singular artistic voice as music and dance. Founded by musician Ranjani Ramakrishnan and dancer DIVYA DEVAGUPTAPU, NIYANTRI's mission is to inspire a collective shift in human consciousness through the transformative power of art. Guest artist Vijay Natesan on Mridangam. Guests of honor Geeta Chandran, Usha Rajeswari, Savita Narasimhan, Prabha Dixit. Seating begins at 5.30 pm. All are welcome.

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INBRIEF



SRMIST signs MoU with Ather for promoting research on EVs

SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST) and Ather Energy entered into a collaboration on Wednesday to promote research and experiential learning on electric vehicle systems. As part of the MoU, Ather handed over three electric scooters to SRMIST. Arief Ahmed Shariff, Head - Talent Acquisition, Fulfilment, and University Relations, Ather Energy; S. Ponnusamy, Registrar, SRMIST, and Leenus Jesu Martin M., Dean, Faculty of Engineering and Technology, SRMIST, were present.

Trans woman electrocuted near Parry’s Corner

A 35-year-old trans woman died after coming into contact with a live wire near Parry’s Corner on Tuesday. The police said Pushpa alias Pushparaj was electrocuted when she attempted to cross the road by climbing over the median.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 9, Thursday), the following articles are available:

- Why does India want fast breeder nuclear reactors? [newsth.live/fastbreederrreactors](#)
- Indian scientists find new way to measure distances in deep space [newsth.live/deepspace](#)

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Despite having nine large waterbodies, residents do not get clean groundwater

They say that if the government removes encroachments and brings excess water from Chembarambakkam to the lakes in the constituency, the drinking water problem can be solved; another issue is that stray animal population keeps rising though the authorities take steps to catch them

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Deepta H. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The Pallavaram Assembly Constituency is famous for many things, for people who have a strong sense of smell, a talcum powder factory and leather manufacturing units are olfactory markers. Though that exhilarating scent persists at that location on the GST Road, residents in many places have no other go but to take in the foul stench of badly laid underground sewage lines that break and pop due to age and quality issues.

“The lines were laid between 2006 and 2011 at a cost of ₹71 crore. You can see raw sewage bubbling up on our streets as good quality pipelines were not used at that time. Now there is another proposal to renew the lines at a cost of ₹890 crore. Hopefully, these will function properly,” said Murugaiyan, Federation of Civic and Welfare Associations of Pallavaram.

Despite having at least nine large water bodies, the constituency does not get clean groundwater and is dependent on tankers for water supply during the summer.

Pallavaram

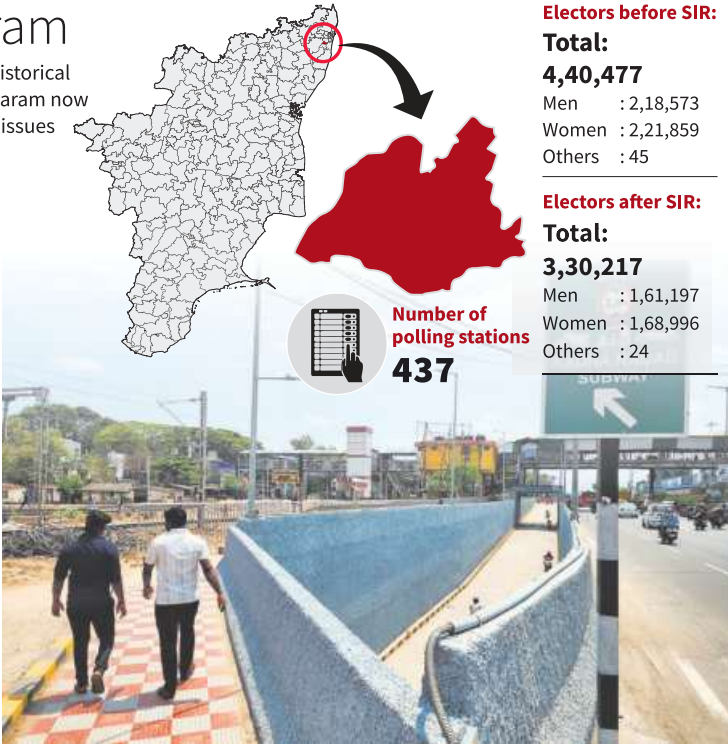
A constituency of historical significance, Pallavaram now grapples with civic issues

KEY ISSUES

- Unclean groundwater
- Stray cattle menace
- Flooding on GST Road at Chromepet
- Encroachment of roads



I. Karunanithi of the DMK defeated S. Rajendran of the AIADMK by a margin of **37,783 votes in 2021** Assembly poll



Major issue: Residents who travel from Radha Nagar gate to Nanmangalam are upset over the withdrawal of bus service 52E. M. KARUNAKARAN

“The lakes such as Moovarasampet Eri, Nanmangalam eri, Hastinapuram eri, Nemilicheri eri, Sembakkam Eri, Putheri Eri, and Pallavaram Periya Eri have shrunk and the channels that used to bring rain waters during the monsoon have all vanished. If the government removes encroachments and brings excess water from Chembarambakkam to these lakes, our drinking

water woes can be done away with,” said V. Santhanam, senior activist from Chromepet, who has conducted many protests to get facilities for residents.

He adds that the issue of the flooding of a section of the GST Road near Vetri Theatre should be resolved soon.

“The Highways Department paid the Railways to construct drains beneath the railway tracks two

years ago, but the work is yet to commence. The government should speed up this project to prevent flooding and the resultant snarls on the arterial road,” he explained.

With the constituency bogged down by civic issues such as Radha Nagar Main Road, Rajendra Prasad Road narrowed down by encroachments, dog and cattle menace, flooding of GST Road, lack of

drinking water supply and encroachment in 10 lakes, a few members of the public came together recently and even discussed the possibility of opting to not vote. However, they are yet to make a call on the subject.

Road accidents

“Accidents keep happening on Rajendra Prasad Road, which is maintained by the Highways Department. We have had two major fatalities on that road in the last few years. Shops and commercial establishments are taking up road space, but no steps are being taken to ensure safe movement of pedestrians,” said M. Sridhar, another resident.

Like many suburbs, since development happened at its own pace in the constituency spread across Thiruneermalai, Pozhichalur, Thirusulam, Pammal, Chromepet, Hasthinapuram, and Pallavaram, the roads are narrow and not equipped to carry increasing traffic.

A section of the Tambaram Corporation is part of the constituency. “The civic body is struggling for funds and is yet to even lay underground drains in many places.”

“The roads have become narrow and rush hours witness traffic jams

everyday. One major grievance pertaining to transportation is the stoppage of bus route 52E for residents travelling from Radha Nagar gate to Nanmangalam. There is no bus or share-autorickshaw facility. Autorickshaws fleece commuters and charge between ₹100 and ₹250 depending on the time in that stretch for a distance of just 2.5 km,” said Shanmuga Mahalingam, a resident.

I.M. Kannappan, another resident, said that the issue of stray dogs and stray cattle was not being dealt in an effective manner. “The authorities come with a vehicle and catch a few animals sometimes. Their population keeps increasing despite such measures. At nights, two-wheeler riders and pedestrians are chased by dogs.”

Residents like M. Gurumurthy, say that though the municipalities have hiked property taxes, residents were not getting sufficient facilities.

“Garbage clearance is not done properly, which also encourages the stray animals on the roads. The burial grounds are not maintained properly. We don’t have enough playgrounds for children,” he said. The DMDK’s Anagai Murugesan and Venkatesan of the IJK are the main contestants this time.

Campaigning turns intense as leaders step up bid to woo voters



Poll frenzy: AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami campaigning in Velachery on Wednesday. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

FIELD POSITION

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With mercury levels rising in Chennai, the heat of the political campaigns has also intensified. AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami resumed his campaign in Velachery, and covered the Assembly constituencies of Saidapet, Virugambakkam, T. Nagar, Anna Nagar, Villivakkam, Kolathur, and Perambur on Wednesday.

He touched upon issues of immediate significance to people, such as inundation of roads, inflation, and the hike in the rates of property and water taxes.

Deputy Chief Minister

Udhayanidhi Stalin was denied permission to campaign in the Perambur Constituency on Wednesday due to the AIADMK leader’s rally at the segment. Mr. Udhayanidhi carried out campaigns in Kolathur, Villivakkam, Egmore, and Harbour constituencies, despite being unwell after 10 days of campaign covering over 40 constituencies. “The sanghis [BJP] and slaves [AIADMK] should never be allowed to rule in Tamil Nadu,” he told the waiting crowd, canvassing votes for party candidate Tamilan Prasanna at Purasawalkam.

Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) chief co-ordinator Seeman, meanwhile, campaigned for his party can-

didates in Perambur, Alandur, Ambattur, and Ponneri Assembly segments. He reiterated that he would not offer free cylinders or monthly direct cash transfers to the public because he would rather provide them with clean, free drinking water, quality education, and a pollution-free environment.

In Mylapore, BJP candidate and former Telangana Governor Tamlisai Sundararajan took to the streets, swapping a standard motorcade for a two-wheeler and an autorickshaw to meet voters.

With BJP’s message, ‘Thamarai Malarndhe Theerum’ (Lotus shall bloom), she went door to door in the Mylapore Tank area and Mandaveli.

Patient undergoes robotic telesurgery at hospital in city

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 23-year-old patient suffering from gastro-esophageal reflux disease (GERD) was treated by robotic fundoplication at GEM Hospital, Perungudi with the surgical gastroenterologist and director, GEM Hospital P. Senthilnathan sitting 1,500 km away.

Using an advanced robotic platform developed by Meril Life Sciences with a dual-console system, the surgeon worked from Vapi in Gujarat, with the supporting surgeon operating the patient in Chennai simultaneously.

In this procedure, the top part of the stomach was wrapped around the lower esophagus to reinforce the valve and prevent

acid reflux. “This is the first time that a hospital has done long-distance robotic telesurgery in the country. In conventional telesurgeries, a single remote surgeon operates in isolation. But this one was different. I was able to interact with the team in Chennai and share control of the robotic arms in real-time. We had a dedicated leased line to ensure seamless connectivity,” explained Dr. Senthilnathan.

The procedure lasted for an hour and a half, and was done after taking due consent of the patient, who has been discharged and is doing well. Such a dual console system would allow surgeries to be performed without doctors and patients having to travel, he added.

Metro Rail to have washrooms in paid area in Phase II stretch

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In a bid to ensure better maintenance, Chennai Metro Rail has built washrooms in the paid area in the Poonamallee - Porur stretch of the phase II project.

Paid area is the space beyond the ticketing gate and a passenger with a valid ticket alone will be able to access the washrooms in the concourse level after crossing these gates.

In the 54-km phase I project, washrooms were constructed in the paid area in many stations, in some of the underground stations, it was built in the unpaid area. After coming down the stairs or escalator, anyone can access the washrooms if it is in the unpaid area.

According to officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limit-



CMRL officials say some people stole faucets in Phase I network stations. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

ed (CMRL), in the washrooms built in the unpaid area, the staff are facing a host of issues.

“Those who are not passengers are using the washrooms in the unpaid area. This was not an issue for us. But the problems began to arise when people started using the washrooms to bathe. Some were stealing faucets and da-

maging the toiletries,” said an official. Cleanliness also has become an issue in these stations, which include Chennai Central, Thousand Lights, Anna Nagar Tower, Anna Nagar East, Government Estate, Koyambedu, Thirumangalam, and High Court.

Since the issues persisted in the phase I network, CMRL decided to have washrooms in the paid area in the Poonamallee -Porur stretch of the phase II network. “This way, we can ensure that passengers have access to well-maintained washrooms as much as possible. It will also be convenient for the staff to clean the washrooms,” another official said.

Meanwhile, the renovation of the toilets in the phase I network is currently under way in some of the stations.

YouTuber ‘Savukku’ Shankar arrested in Andhra Pradesh

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai City Police arrested YouTuber ‘Savukku’ Shankar alias A. Shankar in Andhra Pradesh, after he had been repeatedly challenging the police on social media to arrest him.

He was earlier arrested

on December 13, 2025, based on FIRs registered by the Saidapet and Adambakkam Police Stations in connection with alleged extortion cases. Subsequently, his mother, A. Kamala, filed a habeas corpus petition and another petition seeking specialised medical treatment for his health ailments, including

cardiac complications. On December 26, 2025, a Division Bench of the Madras High Court granted interim bail, subject to certain conditions.

Subsequently, the State, represented by the city police, filed a writ petition seeking cancellation of the interim bail, on the grounds that he had violat-

ed the conditions imposed by the court.

On March 24, the High Court granted the liberty to the Greater Chennai City Police (GCP) to arrest Shankar if his custody was required in connection with the extortion case.

Police sources said Shankar had been operating from another state and

continued to post defamatory content against public figures on social media.

A special team was deputed to trace him, and he was eventually arrested from a lodge in Andhra Pradesh, where he was staying with his associate, Malathi. Both were brought to Chennai and produced before a court.

Randomisation of polling personnel held

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The second round of randomisation of polling personnel for 16 Assembly constituencies in the city ahead of the election, was held at the Ripon Buildings

on Wednesday. It was presided over by Chennai District Election Officer and Greater Chennai Corporation Commissioner J. Kumargurubaran in the presence of election observers.

The district has 4,085

polling stations across 16 constituencies, for which 19,604 polling personnel were selected in this round.

The first round of randomisation was conducted on March 23 following the release of the Assembly

election schedule on March 15.

Initial training

Initial training for polling officials, including presiding and polling officers, was held on March 28 using training EVMs.

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Tender Notice No: E-HQ-CN-MS-EOT-1-2026-27, Dt:04.04.2026.
For and on behalf of the President of India, The Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer/ General / Construction / Southern Railway / Egmore, Chennai - 600 008 invites E-Tender for the following Work.

Name of the work: Perambur New Railway Hospital - Phase-II - Electrification of C and E Block in New Railway Hospital, Perambur.

Tender Notice No. and Date	E-HQ-CN-MS-EOT-1-2026-27, Dt:04.04.2026.
1	Period of Completion
2	Approximate Cost of Work
3	Cost of Tender form
4	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)
5	Tender Closing Date & Time
6	Tender Opening Date & Time

Complete details can be seen on [www.ireps.gov.in](#).

Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer, Construction, Chennai, Egmore, (For and on behalf of President of India)

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Mr. PRITHVIRAJ CHORDIA (84), Grandfather of Mr. NIKHIL CHORDIA, CHENNAI - 600 001, expired on 08-04-2026. Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai-17 (Ph: 28340500).

DEATH

Jesus said to her, "I am the resurrection and the life. The one who believes in me will live, even though they die." John 11:25

Mr. C. EZHIL JOHNSON
Rtd. Executive Engineer, TNEB
Entered Eternal Glory
on April 6th, 2026
Funeral held on 07.04.2026

Wife - Mrs. Mavis Johnson
Children - Agnita Sharon & Gaiannes Calvin
94440 20638 - Mavis Johnson



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CHIEF GUEST



T Udhayachandran, IAS

Additional Chief Secretary,
Finance Department,
Government of Tamil Nadu

GUEST OF HONOUR



Dr GV Selvam

Vice-president,
Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT)

SPECIAL GUESTS



Dr Sundar R

Director,
Rajalakshmi
Institute of Technology



Dr Vikas Misra

Vice-chancellor,
Hindustan Institute of
Technology & Science.

APRIL 11, SATURDAY

SESSION 1: 11:15 AM - 12:45 PM



**Discovering Engineering:
A Complete Guide to TNEA
Counselling Procedures**

Dr T Purusothaman

Senior official, Directorate of Technical
Education (DoTE), Tamil Nadu

SESSION 5: 3:30 PM - 4:15 PM



**Navigating the Quantum Future -
Education and Career Pathways**

Dr Maheswari R

Principal - Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology

SESSION 2: 12:45 PM - 1:30 PM



**Choosing Medicine as a Career:
Pathways & Growth Opportunities**

E Tharanirajan

Additional Director of Medical Education and
Research, Tamil Nadu

SESSION 6: 4:15 PM - 5:00 PM



**Core Engineering in the Modern Era:
Relevance and Career Prospects**

Dr MS Haji Sheik Mohammed

Dean - School of Infrastructure, B.S. Abdur
Rahman Crescent Institute of Science and
Technology, Vandalur, Chennai.

SESSION 3: 2:00 PM - 2:45 PM



**Default Life to Dream Life:
Crafting a Career That's
Uniquely Yours**

Prof. T Thyagarajan

Pro-Vice Chancellor, VIT Chennai

SESSION 7: 5:00 PM - 5:45 PM



**Skills Over Degrees:
Redefining Career Success
in the AI-Driven Economy**

Dr Raghavan Santhanam

Director - School of Ports, Terminal
Management & Logistics, Symbiosis
Skills and Professional University,
Pune

SESSION 4: 2:45 PM - 3:30 PM



**Careers in Aviation: Pathways
Beyond the Cockpit**

Dr R Asokan

Dean of Aeronautical and Aerospace
Engineering - HITS

APRIL 12, SUNDAY

SESSION 1: 10:00 AM - 11:30 AM



**Career Counselling in the
Age of Emerging
Technologies**

Jayaprakash Gandhi

Career Consultant.

SESSION 5: 2:30 PM - 3:15 PM



**Skill Development and Industry
Expectations from Students**

V Udaya Sankar

Director, NASSCOM Talent Council,
Co-founder, Maatram Foundation

SESSION 2: 11:30 AM - 12:15 PM



How to Crack JEE & NEET*

Prof. A Ravishankar

Expert Professor Mathematics,
Ahaguru

SESSION 6: 3:15 PM - 4:00 PM



**Future of Work & Learning
in the AI Era**

Rajiv Tandon

Chief Executive Officer - BITS Pilani Digital

SESSION 3: 12:15 PM - 1:00 PM



**Degrees + Skills = Success:
The New Formula for Career Growth**

Dr G Selvakumar

Director - Engineering & Scientific Research and
Strategic Collaborations, Vinayaka Mission's
Research Foundation (VMRF), Chennai Campus

SESSION 7: 4:00 PM - 5:00 PM



**Careers in Media and
Entertainment**

Suresh Chandra Menon

Actor, Writer & Director

SESSION 4: 1:00 PM - 1:45 PM



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From Page One

EC names Sai Kumar
T.N. Chief Secretary



M. Sai Kumar assumes office at the Secretariat in Chennai on Wednesday evening.

A few hours after the EC’s direction, DMK president and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin objected to transferring out Mr. Muruganandam as the Chief Secretary and said the Commission was “only short of campaigning for the BJP on the field”. The Chief Minister termed the transfer as “arbitrary” and a “political act”.

Taking to social media, Mr. Stalin said it was a “matter of shame” that the EC, which was to remain independent and conduct fair elections, was implementing the “commands” of the BJP-led Union government. The scope provided by the Constitution to the Commission was not to discharge functions favouring the BJP, he said.

Pointing out that the CS and the DGP in election-bound Assam have not been transferred as yet and those in Bihar were not transferred when the State went to the polls, Mr. Stalin said the Commission had transferred these authorities in Tamil Nadu “only at the behest of the BJP”.

Stating that it would not be appropriate for the EC to “join hands with the BJP and the AIADMK” in Tamil Nadu and allow irregularities in conducting elections, Mr. Stalin said polling personnel would be here today but may go tomorrow. It would be a grave danger for the country and for the conduct of elections, if the Commission, provided for by the architects of our Constitution, acted in a partisan manner, he said.

Criticising the Prime Minister and the BJP government led by him for enacting a law providing the government with powers to appoint the Chief Election Commissioner, contrary to the Supreme Court judgment, Mr. Stalin said the transfer of the CS and the DGP in Tamil Nadu and other non-BJP ruled States only reflected that neither the Prime Minister nor the BJP government led by him realised the sanctity of the EC.

“These actions only reflect that the democracy’s last hope in the EC has turned saffron,” Mr. Stalin said. The transfer of any number of officials would not stop the defeat of the BJP in Tamil Nadu, Mr. Stalin said, adding that the actions of the EC reportedly favouring the NDA, comprising the AIADMK and the BJP, was the abuse of power.

INBRIEF

Anbumani flags lack of
safety for women in T.N.

PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss on Wednesday flagged the issue of deterioration in women’s safety in Tamil Nadu during a campaign in Sholinghur. He said former Chief Minister Edappadi K. Palaniswami brought in 7.5% reservation for government school students in NEET. He also passed a law for 10.5% reservation for Vanniyars in Most Backward Classes category, but the DMK ensured it was not implemented.

DMK will not stand by and
watch if rights of southern
States are at stake: Stalin

Criticising the hurry to convene a special session of Parliament on delimitation, amid elections to the Assemblies in five States, the Chief Minister asks why the entire process is shrouded in secrecy

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Wednesday posed a series of questions to the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the special Parliament session on delimitation.

He said the DMK would not stand by and watch “any attempt that places the rights of the southern States at stake while handing over greater power to the north”.

In a social media post, Mr. Stalin said: “Do not turn a calm south into a storm.”

Mr. Stalin further said Mr. Modi must answer the “fair and pressing questions” raised by the people of the south.

“Why is the Union BJP government shrouding the entire delimitation process in secrecy instead of com-



M.K. Stalin

ing clean about how it intends to carry it out?” Mr. Stalin asked.

Previous deferment

Recalling that in 2001, former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee deferred delimitation for 25 years in the interest of the nation, Mr. Stalin asked: “What is Prime Minister Modi’s answer to the just and reasonable demand of the southern States to follow the same path today?”

Mr. Stalin further asked: “What is the tearing hurry to convene a special session of Parliament right in the middle of five State elections? Why is the Union government brushing aside the fair and reasoned demand of Opposition leaders to hold the special session after April 29? What is it trying to hide?”

Contending that “forcing through far-reaching Constitutional amendments, without even convening an all-party consultation, is nothing short of dictatorship,” Mr. Stalin said: “The questions raised by the Opposition and the media are not being answered. Will the questions of the people at least be answered?”

“This is [about] the future of the people who live here. Any decision taken without our consent, without even engaging with us, will not be accepted, come what may. The South de-

mands #FairDelimitation!”

EPS’ criticism

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami criticised Mr. Stalin for raising the issue of delimitation of Lok Sabha and Assembly constituencies.

Addressing voters of T. Nagar in support of his party’s nominee B. Sathya, he said the issue was applicable not just to Tamil Nadu but to the entire country.

Even though Union Ministers had clarified that no harm would be caused to the State, Mr. Stalin was repeatedly raising the matter because he had nothing else to criticise the AIADMK and its allies over, he said.

Mr. Palaniswami said it was because of a “cordial” relationship that his government had with the Centre that the expansion of Chennai Metro Rail was sanctioned to the tune of ₹63,000 crore.



DMK MP Kanimozhi campaigning for party’s Yercaud candidate T.M. Revathi Matheswaran in Salem on Wednesday. E. LAKSHMI NARAYANAN

Victory for DMK front
can trigger change at
Centre: Kanimozhi

The Hindu Bureau
SALEM

DMK MP and deputy general secretary Kanimozhi Karunanidhi on Wednesday said a massive victory for the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance in the Assembly polls should signal the possibility of a change of government at the Centre.

Campaigning for the party’s Yercaud candidate T.M. Revathi Matheswaran near Ayodhiyapattinam railway gate here, she alleged that the AIADMK and the BJP, which had acted against the people and betrayed the State, had formed an alliance.

She said Chief Minister M.K. Stalin had been consistently voicing concern

over the dilution of the rural employment guarantee scheme (MGNREGS).

Criticising the Centre, she said Prime Minister Narendra Modi was attempting to decide on wages and allocation of work “from Delhi”. She also criticised AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami for not opposing the changes to the scheme and accused him of siding against the interests of the State.

Condemning remarks made by Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on the Metro Rail project during a campaign in Madurai, she said the DMK would not be cowed down by “threats” and urged voters to deliver a “befitting lesson” through the ballot.

DMK, BJP alliances in a shambles due to infighting: Vijay

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUNELVELI

The electoral alliances of the DMK and the BJP are in a shambles as infighting among the constituents is so intense that they would not vote for even their alliance party candidates in the upcoming Assembly election, TVK founder and actor C. Joseph Vijay alleged on Wednesday.



Crowd-puller: TVK founder Vijay during the roadshow held in Thoothukudi on Wednesday. N. RAJESH

‘Real Congress’

He claimed that a section of the Congress had been “purchased” by the DMK, while the “real Congress” was with the TVK, which was striving hard to save the secular fabric.

Addressing an election rally in Palayamkottai, Mr. Vijay said the electoral alliances stitched together by the DMK [the Secular Progressive Alliance] and the BJP [the National Democratic Alliance led by the AIADMK] were in disarray owing to intense in-

fighting among their constituents, which would result in losses for them in the upcoming election.

“They [the BJP and the DMK] could not indulge in corruption after my arrival, which has angered them. Hence, they are fomenting trouble to keep

me out of politics and prevent me from meeting you all. They can never come back to power, despite their alliance and electoral arithmetic; this is because of you and the ongoing infighting. Precisely, the sound of the whistle [the TVK symbol] is much loud-

er, even within their families,” Mr. Vijay said.

Without going into the details of the Karur stampede, the actor said the people were fully aware of the facts, even though his political opponents were trying to blame him for the tragedy. “However, you

have rejected all these malicious theories and stood by me. Now, special rules and new standard operating procedures are being created only to cripple my electioneering, but they have failed miserably. A personal malicious campaign was also orchestrated just 30 days ahead of the polls, which you rejected. Now, *Jana Nayagan* [a film starring him] has been crippled with the motive of politically and professionally targeting me. But this will also fail to derail me,” Mr. Vijay said.

“While political leaders in Tamil Nadu have either started their own outfits or joined political parties to reach out to the people, I started the TVK only after becoming a member of every family in Tamil Nadu. The bond between you and me continues through several lives,” the actor added.

He assured the public that the State would bene-

fit from the TVK’s “corruption-free rule”, which would ensure the rule of law and “crush substance abuse”.

Thoothukudi roadshow

Following his election campaign in Palayamkottai, Mr. Vijay arrived in Thoothukudi around 5:30 p.m. for a roadshow. Standing atop an open van in the Third Mile area, he greeted the public – comprising a large number of youngsters – lined up along the route.

The roadshow proceeded along Palayamkottai Road and continued up to VVD Junction, covering nearly 2.5 km.

At the VVD Junction, a sea of people thronged his campaign vehicle to catch a glimpse of him, slowing down the progress of his van.

The Thoothukudi police had made elaborate security arrangements in view of the roadshow, which concluded around 6 p.m.

Forests bordering Bhavanisagar reservoir
see four elephant deaths in March alone

Wilson Thomas
COIMBATORE



Summer retreat: The reservoir attracts wild elephants as it is the largest water source in the region. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Forests bordering the Bhavanisagar reservoir’s water storage areas near Sirumugai in Coimbatore district have witnessed a string of elephant deaths, with four found dead in March alone.

Sources said the carcasses of two female and two male elephants were found at Pethikuttai in Mokkamedu forests. Two of them were found in a decomposed state.

This cluster of deaths within a short span could imply a worrying streak, similar to the ones reported in forests abutting the water storage areas of the reservoir in 2020-2022, the sources added.

According to them, delay in the detection of carcasses could severely compromise the ability to ascertain the actual cause of death. Autopsy findings of severely decomposed carcasses are unreliable and samples collected for his-

topathology and toxicology often fail to yield conclusive results, they said.

Autopsy results

In this case, autopsies could be performed only on the two carcasses that were not decomposed. The results showed symptoms of liver and intestinal diseases.

Officials familiar with the Coimbatore Forest Division said the reservoir saw a congregation of wild elephants as it was the largest source of water in the region during the onset of

summer, which coincides with the last leg of the annual migration of elephants. Weak elephants remain near the water source, while others return to their home range.

Consumption of pods

D. Venkatesh, Chief Conservator of Forests, said the vegetation in Pethikuttai largely comprised *Prosopis juliflora* (*Seemai Karuvellam*), pods of which were consumed by elephants in large quantities in the absence of other options. Over 200 sprouts of

the species have been observed in a single dung bolus from Pethikuttai in the past, he said.

“Studies done on domestic animals indicate that consumption of pods can cause toxic effects. As part of the government’s mission to remove the species, around 50% of *Prosopis juliflora* trees have been removed from Pethikuttai,” said Mr. Venkatesh, adding that the department was conducting a detailed study by sending the samples to Indian Veterinary Research Institute in Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu Veterinary and Animal Sciences University.

A total of 14 elephants were found dead in Pethikuttai Reserve Forest between 2020 and March 2022. Of them, seven had liver disease. Samples taken from two elephants had tested positive for organophosphorus compounds, hinting at potential chronic poisoning from pesticides used in agricultural crops.

HC Bench orders joint survey
of Thirupparankundram hill

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI



The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court on Wednesday asked the Madurai Collector to direct the revenue authorities to extend their cooperation for conducting a joint survey of the Thirupparankundram hill with the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).

The joint survey should be concluded in May, the court said.

A Division Bench of Justices G.R. Swaminathan and S. Srimathy passed the direction while hearing the contempt petition filed by Hindu Dharma Parishad, Madurai, seeking compliance of an earlier court direction.

The Hindu Dharma Parishad had sought a direction to bring the entire Thirupparankundram hill under the control of the Centre and the ASI.

The court posted the matter for hearing to the first week of June.

The Hindu Dharma
Parishad had sought
a direction to bring
the entire hill under
the control of the
Centre and the ASI

The court in 2025 granted liberty to Hindu Dharma Parishad to give a fresh representation to the Centre and the ASI, who were in turn directed to consider it and pass appropriate orders after afford-

ing due opportunity to all the parties concerned, at the earliest.

Interim stay extended

Meanwhile, a Division Bench of Justices N. Sathish Kumar and M. Jothiraman extended till June 4 an interim stay on the contempt of court cases pending before the Single Bench with regard to the *Karthigai Deepam* row. The court was hearing the Letters Patent Appeals filed by the authorities concerned.

Vaiko urges
Union govt. to
drop nuclear
reactor project
at Kalpakkam

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

MDMK general secretary Vaiko on Wednesday urged the Union government to abandon the 500 MW Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor project at Kalpakkam, citing safety concerns.

Referring to Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s recent social media post that the Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor at Kalpakkam attained criticality on April 6, Mr. Vaiko said the Department of Atomic Energy began constructing the reactor in 2004, and that it was originally scheduled to be commissioned in 2010.

Pointing out that some countries had abandoned this type of reactor, he said experts had raised concerns over the use of plutonium as its fuel and had warned that the resulting waste could be used to make nuclear weapons.

Logic may not be the right tool to examine belief systems: SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday said courts cannot hollow out religion in the name of reform, and that logic may not be the right tool to examine faith and belief systems.

The remarks from the nine-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant came during the second day of hearing a reference triggered by a 2018 judgment upholding menstruating women's right to enter and worship at the Sabarimala shrine in Kerala. Justice B.V. Nagarathna said "in the name of social reform, a religion cannot lose its identity", echoing the Centre's stand that the core of a religious faith cannot be sacrificed citing reform.

Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, for the Centre, submitted that reform must come from within the religion. "If I believe in something and it is not against public order, morality or health, there cannot be a judicial review based on rationality and science," Mr. Mehta said. "The concept of logic cannot be applied to religion," Justice M.M. Sundresh observed.

Mr. Mehta read out senior advocate Nani Palkhivala's arguments quoted in the judgment in *Seshamalai versus State of Tamil Nadu* that "under the pre-text of social reform, the State cannot reform a religion out of existence". The 1972 case had dealt with Tamil Nadu law which end-

'No devotee of Ayyappa would have come to SC'

Justice B.V. Nagarathna said a devotee of Lord Ayyappa would not have filed the writ petition in 2006 challenging the exclusion of menstruating women from the Lord Ayyappa temple in Kerala. "If a non-devotee, a person who is not concerned with the temple, challenges it, can this court entertain that writ petition?" Justice Nagarathna asked.

ed the hereditary right of succession to the office of Archakas.

The Centre argued that the court had gone wrong in restricting the right to religious freedom to only "essential religious practices". Hinduism, he said, for example, was not a 'one-creator-one-book' faith, but was host to a plurality of beliefs. It would be impossible for courts to apply a strait-jacket approach to distinguish between core beliefs or practices and mere superstition.

"What is 'superstition' to one section of the public may be a matter of fundamental religious belief to another... Something superstitious for me may be a religious practice for Nagaland," Mr. Mehta said.

Chief Justice Kant said the term 'essential' was not there in the Constitution and was a judicial creation. Mr. Mehta said the courts cannot become theological censors to decide whether a religious practice was superstition or not.

NDA trying to buy votes, say Left, Cong. on Kerala poll eve

BJP rubbishes allegations; candidates spend the day meeting community groups and workers; Cong. continues to battle internal rift; key PCC official quits and declares support for Pinarayi

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Silent campaign on the eve of the Assembly election in Kerala on Wednesday was anything but silent.

Opposing campaigns indulged in muckraking in a last-minute bid to recast the electoral agenda to their advantage as the clock wound down to the voting day on Thursday.

Political sniping seemed fierce in battleground Assembly constituencies, where a few hundred votes could possibly tip an election, and the stakes are consequently high for the three alliances.

The ruling Left Demo-



Officials collect election material and voting machines from a centre in Thiruvananthapuram on Wednesday. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

cratic Front (LDF) and the Opposition United Democratic Front (UDF) sought to gain a propaganda advantage over the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) on poll eve.

They accused the NDA

of seeking to buy votes, especially of needy, ageing voters, chiefly in Palakkad, where the Congress sought to put the BJP candidate, Sobha Surendran, in the dock on charges of election fraud. The Congress and

the ruling CPI(M) also raised similar allegations against the NDA in Thrissur. The BJP described the accusations as outlandish.

The Congress continued to battle internal dissensions on poll eve. Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) secretary D.V. Vinod Krishna resigned from the party and declared support for a "third Pinarayi Vijayan government." Another Congress dissident N.S. Nussor sought to put the party on the defensive on the UDF's Wayanad rehabilitation scheme by petitioning the State Police Chief to investigate alleged misappropriation of funds collected from the public.

Search continues for missing 15-year-old

The Hindu Bureau
SHIVAMOGGA

Days after a Kerala trekker was safely rescued in Kodagu after spending four days alone in a forest, a 15-year-old girl from Palakkad in Kerala went missing during a family trip to Chikkamagaluru in Karnataka.

The girl reportedly went missing near Manikyadhara, a popular waterfall in Bababudangiri Hills, around 6 p.m. on April 7. Her family members

searched for her for some time and then alerted the police around 8.30 p.m.

Chikkamagaluru Superintendent of Police Jiten-dra Kumar Dayama told *The Hindu* that the police and a team from the Forest Department searched for the girl throughout the night. They used thermal drones as well. They continued the operation till 4.30 a.m. on Wednesday.

A disaster response team has arrived at the site to join the search.

ACB arrests two police officers in bribery case

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Two police officers posted at the Rajiv Gandhi International Airport Police Outpost were arrested by the Anti Corruption Bureau (ACB) sleuths while allegedly accepting a bribe of ₹2 lakh, part of a ₹5 lakh demand, in exchange for extending official favours in a criminal case.

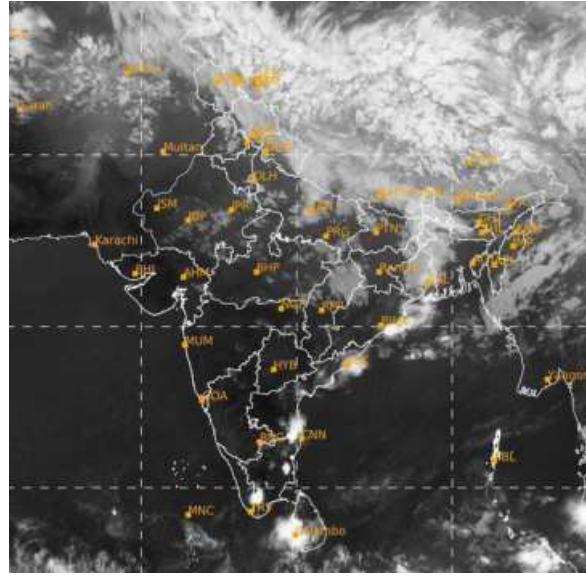
According to the ACB, Inspector Sampathi Kana-kaiah and Sub-Inspector

U.K. Siddeshwar were detained on April 7 by the Rangareddy Range unit when they accepted the bribe from a complainant. The officers had demanded the amount to refrain from implicating and arresting the complainant's family members in a case registered at the RGIA police station in Shamshabad.

Both officers were arrested and produced before the special court for SPE and ACB cases in Nampally for judicial remand.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Thursday: Heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Mizoram and Tripura. Thunderstorm with lightning/gusty winds likely at isolated places over Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhnad, Bihar and West Bengal. Hot and humid weather likely at isolated places over Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	4.....	31.2.....	19.8.....	Kozhikode		34.9.....	24.7.....
Ahmedabad		35.8.....	24.7.....	Kurnool		40.5.....	26.3.....
Aizawl		29.9.....	16.2.....	Lucknow		27.0.....	18.8.....
Allahabad		30.8.....	20.4.....	Madurai		38.4.....	26.4.....
Bengaluru		35.2.....	22.0.....	Mangaluru		32.5.....	23.2.....
Bhopal		33.2.....	22.0.....	Mumbai		33.0.....	25.6.....
Bhubaneswar		34.8.....	22.8.....	Mysuru		36.0.....	19.0.....
Chandigarh		24.0.....	13.4.....	New Delhi		28.2.....	16.8.....
Chennai		37.5.....	27.6.....	Patna		29.0.....	24.2.....
Coimbatore		37.6.....	22.4.....	Port Blair		32.8.....	25.8.....
Dehradun		23.0.....	14.6.....	Puducherry		35.6.....	28.2.....
Gangtok		15.6.....	10.4.....	Pune		34.2.....	21.1.....
Goa		34.5.....	24.1.....	Raipur		38.1.....	24.0.....
Guwahati		30.4.....	17.8.....	Ranchi		31.8.....	17.6.....
Hubballi		37.0.....	21.0.....	Shillong		28.1.....	10.4.....
Hyderabad		37.4.....	23.0.....	Shimla		28.1.....	4.8.....
Imphal		26.3.....	14.5.....	Srinagar		21.1.....	8.8.....
Jaipur		28.6.....	17.6.....	Thiruvananthapuram		37.1.....	25.7.....
Kochi		31.6.....	26.8.....	Tiruchi		37.9.....	27.0.....
Kohima		22.0.....	12.0.....	Vijayawada		38.4.....	26.7.....
Kolkata		31.5.....	20.5.....	Visakhapatnam		34.4.....	27.2.....

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		43		52		40	
Bengaluru		15		48		60	
Chennai		15		11		32	
Delhi		11		22		54	
Hyderabad		17		39		17	
Kolkata		18		36		39	
Lucknow		10		27		38	
Mumbai		3		13		24	
Pune		3		15		108	
Visakhapatnam		32		72		16	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide: Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide: Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide: High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

BUSINESS CONNECT

A Business Initiative

Sathya Agencies Announces IPO



Sathya Agencies Limited, has filed its Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) with the Securities and Exchange Board of India to raise up to Rs. 6,000 million through an Initial

Public Offering (IPO). The offer comprises a fresh issue of Rs. 3,000 million and an offer for sale of Rs. 3,000 million by promoter shareholders. Proceeds from the fresh issue will be used for acquiring Unilet Appliances Private Limited, repaying borrowings, and general corporate purposes. As of January 31, 2026, the company operates 427 stores across South India, offering a wide range of electronics and appliances through partnerships with over 150 brands and distributors.

ICEEE 2026 Attracts Medical Minds



The fourth edition of the International Conference on Endocrinology, Embryology & Endoscopy (ICEEE) was held at Hilton Chennai, bringing together over 200 doctors for a focused masterclass on IVF and fetal medicine. Organised by BloomLife Hospital Pvt. Ltd. in association with ISUOG, the conference featured parallel sessions and hands-on workshops. Experts including Gautham Allahbadia and Suresh Seshadri shared insights on evolving IVF protocols, AI in fertility, and fetal imaging. Practical simulator sessions and new approaches like IVF Lite PGTA highlighted the event's emphasis on innovation, accessibility, and improved patient outcomes.

Lions Club's Diagnostic Centre



The Lions Club of Madras North donated advanced medical equipment to the Public Health Centre strengthening its diagnostic capabilities. The contribution includes key instruments such as an auto analyser, CBC cell counter, ELISA analyser, incubator, HbA1c analyser, and other essential pathology and microbiology equipment. Established in 1966, the centre serves residents of T. Nagar, West Mambalam, Ashok Nagar, and K.K. Nagar, handling around 300 outpatients daily with 100 inpatient beds. Equipped with ICU, coronary, and maternity services, it remains a trusted healthcare provider. Trustees expressed gratitude to the Lions Club for its continued support and commitment to community healthcare.

IMTOF & IPPEX 2026 Concludes



IMTOF 2026 and the International Plastics & Polymers Exhibition (IPPEX) 2026, organised by the Madras Machine Tools Manufacturers' Association, concluded successfully at the Chennai Trade Centre. The five-day exhibitions brought together over 400 exhibitors and over 42,000 business visitors from over 20 countries, showcasing advancements in machine tools, automation, plastics, and polymers. Live demonstrations of CNC systems, laser cutting, robotics, and smart manufacturing solutions drew strong engagement from sectors such as automotive, aerospace, and MSMEs. The event facilitated key business interactions, partnerships, and product launches.

ICL Fincorp Opens NCD Issue



ICL Fincorp has announced a public issue of secured redeemable non-convertible debentures (NCDs), opening on April 10, 2026, with an effective yield of up to 12.25 percent. The issue closes on April 24 and is rated ACUITF BBB-/Stable. With a face value of Rs. 1,000, the offering includes multiple tenure options ranging from 13 to 72 months, with monthly, annual, and cumulative interest plans. The minimum investment is Rs. 10,000. Proceeds will support business growth and service expansion. Backed by over 35 years of operations, the NBFC continues to expand its pan-India presence under the leadership of K. G. Anilkumar.

'bob SAMVAD' Launches In Mumbai



Bank of Baroda launched its AI-powered, multilingual conversational platform, bob SAMVAD, in Mumbai, with M. Nagaraju, Secretary, Department of Financial Services, officiating. This industry-first initiative aims to enhance customer interactions by bridging language barriers and improving service delivery at branches. Nagaraju praised the bank's innovative technology for promoting inclusivity. Dr. Debadatta Chand, Managing Director & CEO, said, "This initiative reflects our commitment to operational excellence by combining technology with customer-centric design." Developed in-house, bob SAMVAD supports real-time communication across 22 languages, will be rolled out in 250 branches across South India and Maharashtra.

AUROVILLE FOUNDATION
Autonomous body under Department of Higher Education
Ministry of Education, Government of India
Auroville -605101, Tamil Nadu

CORRIGENDUM

Due to administrative reasons, the date of Walk-in Interview on 18.04.2026 notified for Accountant positions (On contract-purely on temporary basis) vide Advertisement No. AVF/R/Admin/2026/01 stands postponed to 09.05.2026 (Saturday). All other conditions remain unchanged except the date of Walk-in-interview. The candidates can continue to submit applications upto the time of reporting for Walk-in-Interview. Candidates can refer website of the Auroville Foundation at www.aurovillefoundation.org for further details.

Officer on Special Duty

इण्डियन ओवरसीज बैंक
Indian Overseas Bank
अपको प्रति का सेवा सचो Good people to grow with

Information Technology Department
Central Office: 763, Anna Salai, Chennai-600002

Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:

GOVERNMENT E - MARKET PORTAL - SUPPLY, INSTALLATION AND MAINTENANCE OF 250 ALL IN ONE PC's.

BID NO: GEM/2026/B/7405670 DATED 06.04.2026

The Above RFP tender document is available and can be downloaded from the following websites www.iob.bank.in & www.gem.gov.in For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website www.gem.gov.in

BENGALURU CENTRAL CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer,
Sir C.V. Ramannagar Division, 8th Cross, 12th A Main Road, HAL 2nd Stage, Indiranagara, Bengaluru-560038

No.: EE/CVR/KPPP/01/2026-27 Date: 08.04.2026

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Through GOK KPFP Portal only) (Two Cover System)

Tenders on item rate basis are invited by the undersigned for the work mentioned below from the registered contractors of Bengaluru Central City Corporation or equivalent registration with CPWD / KPWD / Railways / MES or any State Government Organizations. (Standard Tender Document - KW-04)

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1	Annual Maintenance of Arterial and Sub-Arterial Roads including footpath in CV Raman Nagar. Est. Cost in Lakhs: 125.00, EMD (in Rupees): 2,00,000.00.
2	Annual Maintenance of Strom Water Drains in CV Raman Nagara Constituency. Est. Cost in Lakhs: 384.50, EMD (in Rupees): 5,77,000.00.

Calendar of Events: (1) Tender Document can be downloaded from the GOK e-procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> from **10.04.2026** (2) Pre bid meeting will be held on **15.04.2026** at 3:30 p.m. in the Office of the Executive Engineer, C.V. Ramannagar Division, 8th Cross, 12th A Main Road, HAL 2nd Stage, Indiranagara, Bengaluru. (3) Last date for uploading the filled proposals: **18.04.2026** upto **4:00 p.m.** (4) Date of opening of Technical proposals: **18.04.2026** at **4:30 p.m.** (5) Date of opening of Financial Proposals after approval of Technical Proposals through e-procurement. Further details may be obtained from the above office during office hours or website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/- Executive Engineer, Sir C.V. Raman Nagar Division, Bengaluru Central City Corporation

THE HINDU

Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-;
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE, DATE 7.4.2026

Sr. DEN/CO/WCR, Bhopal acting for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-Tenders against following works, upto 15.30 hours on the dates mentioned against each tender. The complete tender documents and detail information regarding tender, is available on the website <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. NIT can also be seen on the notice board of DRM (W)/WCR/Bhopal office. Manual offers are not allowed against these tenders. For any correction, in these tenders, if necessary, corrigendum will be uploaded on website prior to tender opening date and copy of corrigendum will be placed on Notice Board of this office, which may be seen upto the date of tender opening. Tenderers are requested to offer their rates and submit tenders according to the provisions of GST ACT 2017 **NIT No. WCR-BPL-W-25-26-S-37-180, Date : 27/03/2026, Name of work including Location : Itarsi: Planning, Design, Drawing and Construction of Ballast less track at Itarsi station., Published cost of tender (Rs.) : 53018378.0 3, Earnest Money : 1060400.00, period Completion : 12 Months, Last date for submitting tender : 20/04/2026, NIT No. WCR-BPL-W-25-26-S-38-181, Date : 27/03/2026, Name of work including Location : Part A) Track work (including Formation work) required for Execution of part of PSSS GCT phase-I (deposit work). Part B) Civil works (Minor Bridge extension, RCC Pathway, RCC drain) required for Execution of part of PSSS GCT phase-I (deposit work)., Published cost of tender (Rs.) : 71854022.50, Earnest Money : 1437100.00, period Completion : 12 Months, Last date for submitting tender : 20/04/2026, NIT No. WCR-BPL-W-25-26-C-43-182, Date : 28/03/2026, Name of work including Location : Construction of EI Building and other Civil works for Yard Remodeling of Sant Hirdaram Nagar in connection with provision of suitable turnout and additional loop lines (Phase-I)., Published cost of tender (Rs.) : 19433977.50, Earnest Money : 388700.00, period Completion : 8 Months, Last date for submitting tender : 20/04/2026, NIT No. WCR-BPL-W-25-26-HQ-32-183, Date : 30/03/2026, Name of work including Location : Maintenance/Repairing of second floor in old DRM office building at Habibganj under ADEN (Works) Bhopal., Published cost of tender (Rs.) : 3287679.39, Earnest Money : 65800.00, period Completion : 03 Months, Last date for submitting tender :22/04/2026, NIT No. WCR-BPL-W-25-26-HQ-33-184, Date : 30/03/2026, Name of work including Location : RKMP- Augmentation of Existing Camtech Pit Line No.9 & 10 at RKMP Depot for drainage & storage depots under ADEN(Works)Bhopal including Electrical Work., Published cost of tender (Rs.) : 8593155.36, Earnest Money : 171900.00, period Completion : 06 Months, Last date for submitting tender :22/04/2026, NIT No. WCR-BPL-W-26-27-N-01-01, Date : 02/04/2026, Name of work including Location : Provision of 2.50 Lakh Litre Capacity RCC OH tank in West Colony Guna and 1.0 Lakh capacity RCC OH tank at Bina for Memu car shed with connection to water distribution system in west colony Bina., Published cost of tender (Rs.) : 20860108.31, Earnest Money : 417200.00, period Completion : 12 Months, Last date for submitting tender :24/04/2026, NIT No. WCR-BPL-W-26-27-N-02-02, Date : 02/04/2026, Name of work including Location : Bhopal Division: Provision of One bay Cover Over Platforms of 13 stations in Bina-Guna section Mahadeokhedi (MDVK), Semarkheri (SRKI), Kanjia (KXB), Goneru Bamori (GVB), Pipraigan (PIA), Rahatwas (RTWS), ORR, Hinotia Pipalkhera (HPKA), Ratikheda (RIKA), Shadhoragaon (SHDR), Pilighata (PIGT), Pagara (PGA) and Maban (MABN) stations. (With Electrical Work)., Published cost of tender (Rs.) : 27565927.99, Earnest Money : 551300.00, period Completion : 12 Months, Last date for submitting tender :24/04/2026, NIT No. WCR-BPL-W-26-27-HQ-01-03, Date : 04/04/2026, Name of work including Location : Bhopal- Extension of platform No.1 at RKMP end and dismantling of platform No.1 at Bina end in connection with Yard Remodeling of Bhopal Phase-I to make main line through at both ends under ADEN (Works) Bhopal., Published cost of tender (Rs.) : 7180188.65, Earnest Money : 143600.00, period Completion : 06 Months, Last date for submitting tender :29/04/2026.**

Divisional Railway Manager (W), West Central Railway, Bhopal

स्वच्छ भारत अभियान एक कदम स्वच्छता की ओर



A respite

The U.S. should not allow Israel to sabotage the ceasefire with Iran

After demanding Iran’s unconditional surrender and threatening to erase its civilisation, U.S. President Donald Trump, on April 8, agreed to a two-week ceasefire and to hold direct talks with Tehran on the basis of its 10-point peace formula. Iran has said that it will honour the truce and allow the “safe passage” of vessels through the Strait of Hormuz. This war need not have been launched in the first place. The U.S. and Iran had held multiple rounds of talks and Omani and British officials said that a deal was within reach. But Mr. Trump, aided and abetted by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, ordered the bombing of Iran on February 28, killing its Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, and several others. Mr. Trump gravely miscalculated Iran’s response; it regionalised the conflict by attacking U.S. bases across the Gulf and dragged the global economy into it by taking control of the Strait. True, the U.S. and Israel pulverised Iran over the past 40 days. Yet, the U.S. did not have an easy option to reopen the Strait. Remarkably, Mr. Trump’s central demand to end the war was for Iran to reopen the Strait that was open before he launched the war.

On day 1 of the war, Mr. Trump set several sweeping objectives, including destroying Iran’s missile capabilities, its navy, nuclear programme and pursuing regime change. None has been met. The war has pushed up oil, gas and food prices, aggravating economic woes worldwide. In Iran’s latest 10-point proposal, Tehran has reaffirmed its control over the Strait of Hormuz, demanded a removal of all sanctions and guarantees against future aggression. Far from weakening Iran, the U.S.-Israel war has left it strategically stronger in an increasingly fragile region. If Mr. Trump has realised, even belatedly, the scale of his misjudgement, it is good news for West Asia. Pakistan deserves credit for its constructive diplomatic efforts that helped bring the two sides closer. But the ceasefire is only a beginning. Wide gaps remain between the U.S.’s 15-point proposal and Iran’s 10-point formula. Iran and Pakistan say the truce applies on all fronts, including Lebanon. Mr. Netanyahu, while welcoming the ceasefire, has ruled out any halt to Israeli attacks in Lebanon. For peace and stability in the region, Israel and its militarism must be reined in. Finally, Mr. Trump must realise that his incendiary rhetoric, his vulgarism and genocidal threats are not just a disgrace to the office he holds but also counterproductive in international diplomacy. He should watch his words and focus on securing a durable peace if he wants to escape the mess he has put himself in.

At long last

India must now revamp its nuclear regulatory regime

The Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) in Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu, achieving first criticality is a genuine cause for satisfaction, albeit a measured one. A Parliamentary Standing Committee reported this year that the project’s final cost is ₹8,181 crore, more than twice the sanctioned amount. Criticality itself is at least 16 years behind schedule; the fast reactor fuel cycle facility is expected to be commissioned by 2029, over a decade late. Poor planning and flawed procurement, abetted by political insulation, are the causes of the delay. The PFBR is the first commercial-scale component of the second stage of India’s nuclear power programme. Its purpose is to use spent fuel, after reprocessing, from the first stage, and depleted uranium to produce more plutonium. In the final stage, reactors will use plutonium and thorium as fuel. The programme’s design is based on India’s abundant thorium deposits, but this sword cuts both ways. The nuclear establishment must also be scrupulous about the PFBR’s performance as it is prepared for commercial operation, and admit mistakes or under-performance plainly. The goal is not to use thorium at any cost but to achieve energy security and self-sufficiency. If the economics of solar and wind power render the current nuclear power paradigm a poor allocation of scarce public capital, that finding should honestly determine policy.

Nuclear power contributes around 3% of India’s electricity from 8.78 GW of installed capacity. The country has committed to becoming a net-zero economy by 2070 amid an energy demand growth that will be among the largest of any major economy over the next two decades. Nuclear power facilities are expected to consume 6% of the land area required for equivalent solar power generation per unit of electricity produced. Considering that India’s biodiversity commitments depend on not converting green cover, nuclear power offers a non-trivial path forward. Breeder reactors are more fuel-efficient, and will also extend the fuel cycle and reduce dependence on uranium imports. The challenge is to realise these merits without squandering time and public money. This means fixing the problems that the PFBR throws up during commissioning, and proceeding with the planned FBRI and FBR2 units at Kalpakkam based on lessons learned, without the opacity that has prevailed so far. The PFBR also comes online alongside the SHANTI Act, private nuclear power operations, the advent of small modular reactors, and a new liability regime. Now is an opportune time for India to revamp its regulatory regime. So far, the AERB and the DAE have reported to the Atomic Energy Commission, which is thus both the promoter and the regulator of nuclear energy. The government must resolve this administrative short-circuit before any new complexities arise.

To say that sports is an emotion in India is an understatement. Although cricket takes up most of the mindshare, the sports ecosystem in India is evolving rapidly with athletes such as Neeraj Chopra and Lakshya Sen bringing attention to the diversity in sports in the right manner. But besides viewership and athletes, the sports ecosystem comprises several key players that keep the growth engine running. One such important, but rather overlooked, component is that of sports goods manufacturing.

Sports equipment manufacturing, a highly labour-intensive sector, plays a significant role in the economics of sport. NITI Aayog and the Foundation for Economic Development (FED) have recently released a report on ‘Realising the export potential of the sports equipment manufacturing market in India’ that details the state of affairs. Culturally, India interacts heavily with sports, but the country contributes only about 0.5% to the nearly \$50 billion global trade in sports equipment. This under-representation is not due to the absence of legacy or capability. Rather, it points to structural issues in the industry that have significantly hampered its ability to reach its full potential.

Diverse manufacturing landscape

India’s manufacturing footprint in sports equipment is geographically concentrated and operationally fragmented. Production still primarily hinges on old, well-established centres such as Jalandhar (Punjab) and Meerut (Uttar Pradesh), which together hold more than an 80% share of domestic output. The sports equipment industry in India is small in terms of production volume and is largely dominated by micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) engaged in labour-intensive segments such as stitched balls, cricket gear, protective accessories and entry-level fitness equipment. If, on the one hand, this artisanal skill level has sustained the industry for a long time, on the other hand, it has restricted scaling, the adoption of new technologies, and the emergence of internationally recognised brands.

One key characteristic of the sector is the high level of diversity in sports equipment manufacturing compared to other sectors. Raw materials, machinery and the techniques of making footballs, for example, are entirely different from the ones required for making hockey sticks or golf shafts. This vast range of differences makes effective policy design exceedingly difficult and often leads to generic interventions that overlook category-specific realities.

To understand the right ways to compete at a global level, we first need to find out what makes local manufacturers inherently less cost-effective.



Sanjeet Singh

Senior Adviser at NITI Aayog



Lakshita Mehrotra

Senior Team Lead at the Foundation for Economic Development (FED)

Critical structural problems are preventing India’s sports equipment industry from reaching its full potential

As per the report, industry data show that Indian firms encounter on average a 15% cost disadvantage when compared to their peers in China and Pakistan. For example, a football produced in India might cost ₹100, while competing countries might be able to produce it for only ₹85-₹87. This gap, which is a result of factors such as higher input prices, inefficient logistical planning, and limited economies of scale, greatly reduces export competitiveness and impacts the pricing power that companies have.

The core issues

Making high-performance sports equipment requires feature-specific items such as specialised polymers, performance fabrics, carbon composites and precision tooling. The issue is that not all of these are produced domestically, and those that are made locally are manufactured on an extremely limited scale. Moreover, import duties on such components, as well as on advanced manufacturing machinery, drive up production costs. For MSMEs which function with extremely low margins, these additional levies essentially hinder the possibility of investing not only in technology upgrades but also in product diversification.

Issues related to ease of doing business aggravate the problem. Manufacturing is mainly concentrated in the northern parts of India, which leads to extremely high logistics costs when exporting goods through distant ports. On top of that, rising land prices, fragmented industrial infrastructure, and industrial delays on account of compliance are some of the other factors that keep on eroding operational efficiency. As these challenges are structural rather than cyclical, smaller firms with weak financial strength are most affected.

Another problem is certification and standards compliance. Globally traded sports equipment must meet the very stringent performance standards laid down by international federations. India lacks certified production facilities that meet international standards for most sports categories; therefore, manufacturers must have their products validated by European labs.

Testing expenses can range from ₹5 lakh to ₹50 lakh per stock keeping unit (SKU) which is an enormous amount for an MSME. Apart from the direct monetary costs, a prolonged certification process also delays market launches, which in turn discourages experimentation and, consequently, impedes innovation.

There are many reasons why the sports sector in India is not expanding rapidly, one of which is demand side problems. India has, by and large, failed to create sports brands with worldwide appeal, similar to those for cricket equipment, that could command premium pricing. The main reasons for the lack of organic global demand for

Indian sports equipment are low marketing investments, few international brand partnerships, and the absence of long-term, athlete-brand relationship-driven demand. Hence, most domestic firms today focus on contract manufacturing at the lowest-value end of the spectrum, whereas they should be aiming for original brand ownership.

Reform, support, upgrade

Addressing these issues is complex and requires a balanced approach. The report outlines a clear pathway with key recommendations. First, rationalise import duties on specialised raw materials and advanced machinery to regain price competitiveness. Second, provide targeted fiscal support, such as export-linked incentives, offsetting certification costs, and aiding participation in international trade platforms. Third, India should leverage its advantage in industries such as technical textiles, footwear production, plastics processing, and light engineering alongside sports goods clusters to enable rapid technological upgrades, increase production scale, and shift toward higher-value, performance-oriented equipment.

In the medium term, India must also establish internationally recognised testing and certification centres, which reduce compliance costs, facilitate quicker time-to-market for new innovations, and showcase India’s intent to be a standards-setting player rather than just a supplier.

Finally, by investing in local raw materials, especially advanced composites and performance fabrics, India can gradually reduce imports and improve supply availability. On the demand side, relying solely on contract manufacturing is insufficient; building strong domestic brands is essential. A unified national campaign involving top athletes, sports federations, industry bodies, and government departments can help showcase Indian sports equipment globally.

Utilising strategic procurement methods linked with India’s forthcoming international sporting events can generate a short-term demand uplift while also promoting domestic production to global buyers.

For long, India has supplied sports goods mainly through indirect global value chains. The next decade offers a chance to change this. With growing domestic sports activity, a reshaping of global supply chains, and opportunities from hosting major international events, the ingredients for change exist. What is lacking is a strategic, well-executed plan to shift from scattered traditional production to large-scale, advanced manufacturing. If India seizes this opportunity, it could become a key player in the global sports economy and set new trends in how sports are played worldwide.

Jan Vishwas 2.0 is all about trust-based compliance

The passage of the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026 by Parliament reflects a conscious and forward-looking policy choice by the Government of India to recalibrate the balance between enforcement and facilitation, and to embed trust as a central pillar of the regulatory framework. The reform signals a clear departure from over-reliance on criminal sanctions toward a more proportionate, predictable, and facilitative approach to compliance.

In recent years, the decriminalisation of minor business-related offences has emerged as a core element of India’s reform agenda. The underlying objective has been consistent: to rationalise compliance requirements, enhance ease of doing business and foster a regulatory culture that promotes voluntary compliance rather than fear-driven adherence. Excessive criminalisation of technical and procedural lapses had created compliance anxiety, discouraged entrepreneurship, and diverted administrative and judicial resources from more serious violations.

A journey of reform

This reform journey began with the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2023, which decriminalised minor offences by amending 183 provisions across 42 Central Acts administered by 19 Ministries and Departments. By replacing criminal penalties for technical and procedural non-compliances with civil penalties or administrative measures, it significantly reduced the compliance burden on businesses and citizens, improving both ease of doing business and ease of living.

Building on this foundation, the 2026 Bill, commonly referred to as the Jan Vishwas 2.0, represents a decisive scale-up of this reform effort. The Bill proposes amendments to 784 provisions across 79 Central Acts administered by 23 Ministries and Departments, including the decriminalisation of 717 provisions. It also rationalises the statute book by removing obsolete and redundant offences, thereby



Chandrajit Banerjee

Director General, The Confederation of Indian Industry (CII)

Driven by clarity and proportionality, Jan Vishwas 2.0 will help shift Indian businesses toward a trust-based compliance culture

strengthening the coherence and credibility of India’s overall regulatory architecture.

Extensive engagement between government, industry bodies, experts and other stakeholders has helped identify provisions where criminal liability was disproportionate to the nature of the offence. Such sustained dialogue has been critical in ensuring that regulatory objectives are preserved even as enforcement mechanisms are made more facilitative. Going forward, continued consultation will remain essential to keep regulation aligned with evolving economic realities.

A process of engagement

The Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) has shaped this reform agenda through sustained, evidence-based policymaker engagement. Industry representations consistently highlighted a large number of statutory offences related to minor and procedural lapses – delays in filings, documentation gaps or clerical errors – that did not warrant criminal prosecution. The CII has emphasised that decriminalisation of such offences strengthens compliance rather than diluting enforcement.

The CII’s advocacy has gone beyond decriminalisation alone. A persistent industry recommendation has been to move away from court-imposed ‘fines’ toward a system of regulatory ‘penalties’ administered by executive authorities, with clear rules, proportionality, and time-bound resolution. The CII has also stressed the need for the retrospective application of decriminalisation reforms, covering cases currently pending in criminal courts. The Jan Vishwas 2.0 seems to address these long-standing concerns very well.

At a broader level, the Jan Vishwas 2.0 reflects a fundamental shift in regulatory philosophy, from criminalisation to trust, proportionality and economic efficiency. It recognises that most technical or procedural violations occur without *mala fide* intent and are better resolved through civil or administrative mechanisms. The reform explicitly retains stringent enforcement for

serious offences where public interest, safety, environmental protection or national priorities are involved. The amendments span key sectors such as exports, textiles, the environment, and transport, and introduce graded enforcement mechanisms, including warnings and lower penalties for first-time or minor violations. Such measures should reduce regulatory uncertainty and boost confidence, especially for micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME) facing high compliance burdens.

Reduces ‘court congestion’

These reforms could significantly help India’s overburdened judiciary. With nearly 50 million cases pending in courts – many for minor procedural or technical violations – shifting such matters out of criminal courts can reduce congestion and improve efficiency. Government indications, post the passing of the Bill in Parliament, suggest many pending minor cases may be reviewed for closure under the revised framework.

The Bill also advances trust-based regulation by introducing tools such as improvement notices and proportionate penalties for first-time contraventions. This approach recognises the reality that most businesses and citizens act in good faith and comply more effectively in a regulatory environment that is clear, predictable and fair.

The success of the Jan Vishwas 2.0 will depend on effective implementation. Strengthening institutional capacity for administrative adjudication, ensuring uniform enforcement practices, and issuing clear guidance to regulated entities will be critical to realising the full benefits of the reform for industry and citizens.

By decisively moving towards a trust-based, proportionate and growth-oriented framework, The Jan Vishwas 2.0 has the potential to create a more predictable, transparent and investor-friendly environment. Ultimately, the reform reinforces a simple yet powerful principle: compliance works best when driven by clarity, proportionality, and – above all – trust.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Ceasefire announcement

The decision by the United States and Iran to observe a conditional ceasefire will bring immense relief to the global community, which has been facing a severe energy crisis. This assumes greater significance in the backdrop of an ominous threat issued by the U.S.

President that ‘a whole civilization will die tonight’. However, Israel’s claim that the ceasefire does not include Lebanon sustains fears that the war may continue during this crucial two-week window. It is Mr. Trump’s responsibility to prevail upon Israel to halt attacks on Lebanon for

meaningful negotiations to take place. **Kosaraju Chandramouli**, Hyderabad

Police brutality

One recalls with deep shock and sorrow the Sathankulam custodial death case. Sadly, such incidents are not

uncommon. When the incident occurred, we pointed out the pitfalls of passing mechanical remand orders (Letters to the Editor,

June 29, 2020). Safeguards were suggested. One hopes that the government acts on those recommendations, as the worst sufferers, as

Corrections & Clarifications

The results of the Kerala Assembly elections are to be declared on May 4, 2026, and not May 3 (Opinion page – Data Point, “Amid welfare pitch, Kerala ranks highest in most indicators”, April 8).

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always, are the poor. Unless all safeguards, as previously noted, are implemented, constitutional guarantees will remain only on paper.

N.G.R. Prasad, K.K. Ram Siddhartha, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The thermal cost of India’s textile surge

India is currently winning the global trade shuffle. As political instability rocks traditional hubs such as Bangladesh, international buyers are pivoting toward Indian textile clusters. But as factories in Tiruppur and Bengaluru take on these surge orders, they are walking into a thermodynamic crisis they haven’t budgeted for.

The crisis is personal before it is industrial. A textile worker in Tamil Nadu loses 50% of her work capacity on a 40°C afternoon; and as she does not have any sick leaves or cooling breaks, she also loses 50% of her day’s wages. She absorbs the cost of a warming planet so that global supply chains remain ‘efficient’. However, the biology of labour is hitting a wall, and India’s textile industry is quietly cracking under the weight.

The crisis of productivity

Between 2001 and 2020, India lost an estimated 259 billion labour hours annually due to heat stress, a productivity haemorrhage exceeding \$600 billion each year. In 2024 alone, that loss spiked to as high as 247 billion hours.

The productivity crisis is no longer a theoretical risk; it is a mechanical and biological reality crippling India’s industrial heartlands. In the manufacturing hubs of Palghar, Maharashtra, factory owners report production capacity dropping by up to 50% as extreme heat triggers hazardous conditions that jeopardise both man and machine. Intense temperatures often restrict operations to just four hours daily, as heat becomes unbearable for the workforce. It also increases the likelihood of workplace injuries and serious health conditions, including heatstroke and dehydration. Industrial equipment, designed for more temperate baselines, frequently overheat, leading to sudden operational shutdowns and technical failures that derail tight production schedules. This physical collapse of the shop floor is mirrored in Karnataka’s textile



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The productivity crisis is no longer a theoretical risk; it is a mechanical and biological reality crippling India’s industrial heartlands

factories, where, indoor temperatures routinely exceed 35-40°C, far above the permitted threshold of 30°C. At these extremes, the “human engine” throttles down as a matter of survival. International studies confirm that at 33-34°C, a worker’s capacity is effectively halved.

As per research published in the *Journal of Political Economy* in 2021, annual output falls by 2% per degree Celsius. On individual hot days, the decline reaches 4%. For India’s textile industry, which employs 45 million people and controls 39% of global cotton cultivation, this crisis has led to operational collapse.

The supply chain trap

Global brands impose strict delivery deadlines and heavy financial penalties for delays. Yet, workers cannot be pushed beyond physiological limits. Thus, factory managers face an impossible choice: ignore worker collapse to meet a shipment, or face financial ruin. As orders shift to India due to regional and political instability, hubs such as Tiruppur are being crushed by a “thermodynamic bottleneck” where surge orders collide with record-breaking heat. This creates a regressive tax on the poor, disguised as a weather problem. While global brands insulate themselves by diversifying sourcing – shifting orders to Vietnam or Mexico – local factory owners lack the bargaining power to renegotiate terms and the burden is pushed downward. Ultimately, the cost is absorbed by the millions of informal workers who have no safety net; when a factory floor becomes a furnace, they don’t just lose productivity, they lose their daily wages. History has shown that when disruption strikes, workers pay the price; for example, during COVID-19, brands cancelled \$2.8 billion worth of orders from Bangladesh in March 2020 alone, affecting approximately 1.2 million workers.

By 2030, India is projected to lose 5.8% of its daily working hours to extreme heat, the

equivalent of 34 million full-time jobs. The supply chain will not break gradually; it will break when orders simply cannot be met because the human element has reached its thermal limit.

The way forward

India has a choice. It can either continue to externalise the cost of a warming planet onto workers, or the country can systematically transit to a climate-smart supply chain. This requires action on five fronts: first, policymakers must recognise heat stress as a supply chain risk and integrate climate-heat projections into industrial policy and trade agreements. Second, industrial clusters must adopt mandatory heat-action plans with enforceable temperature thresholds, cooling breaks, and worker health assessments. Third, financing mechanisms must be reformed. Banks must incorporate climate risk into loan assessments, and governments must offer concessional credit lines supporting investments in cooling systems, water management, and heat-resilient technologies. Fourth, labour protection codes must be strengthened to address heat stress explicitly. Workers must have guaranteed access to clean drinking water, and shaded rest areas. Fifth, innovation must be driven through targeted R&D grants for wearable cooling technologies, heat-tolerant cotton varieties, and energy-efficient manufacturing processes. And finally, international buyers must bear part of the adaptation cost, through fairer pricing and longer lead times. For decades, the global fashion industry has operated on a convenient lie: that the ‘cost of production’ is a static number on a spreadsheet. This number was artificially deflated by a climate we took for granted. The physics of thermoregulation will not bend to profit margins. If heat stress remains invisible in boardrooms, India’s workers will pay in lost wages and shortened lives.

Views expressed are personal.

National polity yet regional sentiment

The BJP should be careful not to fall foul of regional pride in Odisha

STATE OF PLAY

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The observance of *Utkal Dibas* or Odisha Day last week, normally a matter of course, became a subject of intense scrutiny this time, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s letter to Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi put through the sieve of political meaning for any references to the State’s former Chief Minister and socialist leader Biju Patnaik.

In his letter, the PM praised the late leader, stating that, “This is the soil that nurtured the great Biju Patnaik, whose life epitomises strength, courage and an unwavering commitment to nation-building. Biju Babu’s multifaceted persona inspires us all.”

Again, these words shouldn’t have garnered any scrutiny. Biju Patnaik, who was close to Jawaharlal Nehru, was after all, a former Royal Air Force pilot; rescuer of Indonesian freedom fighters Sultan Sjahrir and Achmad Sukarno who were defying a Dutch blockade in 1947; socialist leader; former Chief Minister of Odisha; and father of Biju Janata Dal (BJD) leader Naveen Patnaik. The BJD, now prime rivals to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in Odisha, had been allies of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) in the Vajpayee years and later held strict neutrality on many political issues, rescuing the NDA government over tricky legislations in Parliament as part of a political quid pro quo.

The controversy

However, encomiums for Biju Patnaik by the PM came after a BJP MP, Nishikant Dubey,

made a statement alluding that Biju Patnaik was reportedly under the influence of the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) of the U.S. (the reference to Patnaik was couched within a criticism of former PM Jawaharlal Nehru). Reactions in Odisha were swift and cut across party lines. The normally staid Naveen Patnaik stated that Mr. Dubey needed help with his mental health; BJD members of the parliamentary standing committee on Information Technology headed by Mr. Dubey quit in protest; and other BJP MPs from Odisha gave out statements disagreeing with Mr. Dubey’s comments.

This across-the-line protest on statements that impugned the reputation of Biju Patnaik reveals the stresses of being a national party falling foul of regional sentiments. Mr. Dubey was on safe ground when he was taking to task a national party like the Congress, but when it came to a regional party such as the BJD, with its strong identification with the sentiments of regional pride of their particular States, Mr. Dubey found himself isolated within his own party.

For the BJP, in power for the first time on its own in the State, it was a lesson on how the issue of regional pride can bite when it swings both ways.

During the 2024 Lok Sabha and Assembly polls it was the BJP that invoked Odia pride when the BJD had bureaucrat V.K.Pandian, a TAMILIAN and a close aide of Mr. Naveen Pat-

naik, taking a prominent role in the party’s campaign. Odisha was the first Indian State created on a linguistic basis, in 1936, after a long struggle which emphasised its linguistic and regional pride. Fielding Mr. Pandian as the face of the BJD’s electoral campaign saw the BJP accuse the regional party of transgressing *Odia Asmita* or Odia pride.

The BJD paid the price for this electoral misadventure, losing power after 24 years. Several BJD MPs and leaders had over the years made their way to the BJP as well.

Double-edged sword

Now, the regional pride issue has swung the other way, with the BJD accusing the BJP of being party to an insult to one of the most prominent icons of the State.

The BJP on its part was quick to get all its MPs and leaders to condemn their party colleague, Mr. Dubey, on his statement, with the latter then offering an unconditional apology for his remarks and walking back from the allegations that he had levelled against Biju Patnaik.

The issue of regional and cultural pride is tricky, especially for non-regional parties that are hunting for political space. For the BJP, Mr. Dubey’s statements were at first yet another attack on the Congress, but the consequences of it were felt in Odisha. For the BJD, it was an opportunity for the party to assert before the Odia people, that while national parties may speak the language of regional pride, their national spread can trip them up on issues of sentiment.

The endurance of the tall shadow of Biju Patnaik over Odisha politics shows that regional sentiments are never far from the surface.

Poll-bound Assam trails in health and education indicators

Low basic vaccination, high maternal mortality, and increasing dropout rates at the higher education level are some of the challenges the State faces

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani

With Assam set to vote on April 9, for its 126-member Assembly, in a contest between the incumbent Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress, an indicators-based analysis reveals that the State lags behind others in India in key areas such as health, education, and human development.

Assam’s Human Development Index (HDI) stood at 0.699 in 2023, below the national average of 0.732, placing it 24th among 29 States. The gap with top-performing States remains wide, with Goa and Kerala recording HDI values above 0.86. Economic indicators show a similar trend. The State ranked 18th in per capita net domestic product, with an average of ₹1.59 lakh, significantly lower than the national average of ₹2.05 lakh. However, with an average daily wage of ₹384, the State’s average rural wage level is closer to the national average of ₹398 (**Table 1**).

Health indicators largely present a concerning picture (**Table 2**). The infant mortality rate stands at 31.9, lower than the national average of 35.2. The proportion of stunted children stands at 35%, only marginally lower than the national average. While only a smaller share of households rely on ‘unimproved’ sanitation facilities compared to the national average, Assam is placed among the worst-performing States in this indicator.

Immunisation and maternal health indicators point to deeper structural challenges. Only 67% of children receive all basic vaccinations, which is significantly below the national average of 77%, placing Assam among the lowest-ranked States. Maternal mortality remains particularly high, at 195 per one lakh live births, which is nearly double the national average, making Assam one of the worst-performing States on this in-

dicator. At the same time, some indicators show relatively better outcomes. The share of women aged 15-19 who have begun childbearing is 4.1%, lower than the national average of 6.8%, suggesting some progress in delaying early pregnancies. Health insurance coverage is also relatively high, with nearly two-thirds of households having at least one member covered under a scheme.

Education indicators reveal a contrast between access and outcomes (**Table 3**). Assam records a perfect adjusted net enrolment rate of 100% at the elementary level, indicating near-universal access to schooling. However, the dropout rate stands at 20.3%, placing the State among the worst performers. Enrolment at the higher level is particularly weak; the gross enrolment ratio in higher secondary education is just about 40%. However, gender parity in higher education is relatively balanced, with Assam holding the 9th rank in this indicator. Women related indicators also reflect a mixed picture. The share of women (18.6%) with no schooling is lower than the national average. The State also has a higher share of males (12.5%) with no education. The use of hygienic menstrual products is significantly below the national average, placing Assam among the poorer-performing States on this indicator.

Infrastructure and environmental indicators further highlight uneven development (**Table 4**). Per capita fossil fuel consumption is relatively low compared to the national average, though this likely reflects lower per capita energy use rather than greater efficiency. Rural internet penetration remains limited, placing Assam among the poorer performing States on this measure.

Assam’s profile shows strengths in wage levels, and health coverage but it continues to lag behind in areas such as maternal health, and human development.

With inputs from Nitika Francis and Sambavi Parthasarathy

State scorecard

The data for the tables were sourced from the National Family Health Survey (2021-22), NITI Ayog SDG India Index (2023-24), Global Data Lab, Economic Survey 2024-25 and Parliament question/answers



Table 1: Assam’s values and ranks in terms of Human Development and economic indicators

Indicator	Assam’s value	Assam’s rank (out of 29)	India average	Top States/UTs
Human Development Index (2023)	0.699	24 out of 29	0.732	Goa (0.862), Kerala (0.86), Delhi (0.837)
Per capita net domestic product (₹)	1,59,185	18 out of 23	2,05,324	Delhi (4,93,024), Telangana (3,87,623)
Average daily wage rates in rural areas (₹)	384.8	9 out of 18	398	Kerala (868.7), T.N. (573.2), H.P. (516)

Table 2: Assam’s values and ranks across various health-related indicators

Indicator	Assam’s value	Assam’s rank	India average	Top States/UTs
The share of women aged 15-19 who have begun childbearing (%)	4.1	12 out of 29	6.8	Uttarakhand (2.4%), Kerala (2.4%), Goa (2.7%)
Infant mortality rate (per 1,000)	31.9	19 out of 29	35.2	Kerala (4.4), Goa (5.6), Sikkim (11.2)
The share of population with ‘unimproved’ sanitation facilities (%)	12	26 out of 29	19.3	Mizoram (0.1%), Kerala (0.2%), Sikkim (0.3%)
The share of children aged 0-5 years whose growth is stunted (%)	35	20 out of 29	36	Sikkim (22%), Kerala (23%), Manipur (23%)
Percentage of children with all basic vaccinations (%)	67	26 out of 29	77	Odisha (91%), Tamil Nadu (89%), Himachal (89%)
Women using a hygienic method of menstrual protection (%)	67	25 out of 29	77.6	Tamil Nadu (98.4%), Delhi (97.1%), Goa (96.8%)
Maternal mortality ratio (per 1,00,000 live births)	195	19 out of 19	97	Kerala (19), Maharashtra (33), Telangana (43)
Households with at least one member covered by a health scheme (%)	66.7	7 out of 29	41	Rajasthan (87.8%), Andhra Pradesh (80.2%), Goa (73.1%)

Table 3: Assam’s values and ranks across various education-related indicators

Indicator	Assam’s value	Assam’s rank (out of 29)	India average	Top States/UTs
The share of women (aged 15-49) who have no schooling (%)	18.6	17	22.6	Kerala (0.8%), Mizoram (5.3%), Goa (5.5%)
The share of men (aged 15-49) who have no schooling (%)	12.5	21	10.7	Kerala (2.3%), Goa (3.2%), Mizoram (3.4%)
The average annual dropout rate at the secondary level (classes 9-10)	20.3	26	12.6	Manipur (1.3), H.P. (1.5), T.N. (4.5)
Adjusted Net Enrolment Rate (ANER) in elementary education (%)	100	1	96.5	Multiple States (100%)
Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) in higher secondary (%)	40.1	27	57.6	Delhi (94.9%), H.P. (94.1%), Kerala (85%)
Gender Parity Index (GPI) for higher education	1.09	9	1.01	Kerala (1.44), H.P. (1.33), Nagaland (1.28)

Table 4: Assam’s values and ranks across various environmental and infrastructure-related indicators

Indicator	Assam’s value	Assam’s rank	India average	Top States/UTs
Plastic waste generated per 1,000 population (Tonnes/annum)	1.68	13 out of 23	3.04	Goa (18.9), Delhi (16.9), Telangana (12.5)
Per capita fossil fuel consumption (in kg)	88.42	19 out of 21	166.43	Haryana (341.9), Gujarat (339.2), H.P. (271.7)
Percentage of urban households living in kachha houses (%)	0.8%	13 out of 29	0.9%	Kerala (0%), Haryana (0.2%), Maharashtra (0.2%)
Internet subscribers per 100 population in rural areas	33.66	23 out of 28	38.33	Goa (174.98), Kerala (160.19), Sikkim (104.35)

FROM THE ARCHIVES



FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 9, 1976

Massive pro-Hua rally in Peking

Peking, April 8: The fall of a new “renegade” for “counter revolutionary” activities and the appointment of a successor to the later Premier Chou En-lai gave rise in Peking to-day to the biggest mass demonstration seen in China since the Cultural Revolution of the late Sixties.

Several hundred thousand people, may be a million, took part in the huge assembly, superbly orchestrated by the Chinese communist party to dump Ten Hsiaoping in the ‘rubbish bin of history’.

Tens of thousands poured onto the main avenue of Eternal Tranquillity, beating drums and cymbals and carrying banners pledging support for Mr. Hua Kuo-feng and opposition to Mr. Teng.

Cheer leaders with loudhailers directed the massive congregation of school children, students and workers, which swarmed through the heart of the capital.

Groups carried portraits of Chairman Mao and banners declaring: “We warmly support the two resolution of the Central Committee”.

In the official version of the riots here on Monday, the New China News Agency said more than 100 guards and militiamen were injured, some seriously during the riots.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 9, 1926

Preventing soil erosion

Extensive experiments have been carried about in Ceylon estates with a view of solving the problem of the denudation of the soil, particularly in hilly districts, says a correspondent in “The Statesman” writing from Colombo. Tea estates in India will no doubt, take the greatest interest in whatever methods are suggested to prevent soil erosion whether the suggestion comes from Agricultural Departments or from individual research workers.

Many planters in Ceylon believe that the problem is now particularly solved by the system of ‘contour platforms’ which has been evolved by a well-known Sinhalese planter Mr. C.E.A Dias. This gentleman got the idea from Italy, where the vineyards on steep hillsides are planted according to the contour of the land and he improved this system further so as to prevent any erosion of the surface soil whatever.

CM
YK

Rakesh Singh, out on bail, gets BJP ticket

▼ The Bharatiya Janta Party on Wednesday chose Kolkata strongman Rakesh Singh, an accused in several cases of violence, to contest against senior Trinamool Congress leader Firhad Hakim from the Kolkata Port constituency, a day after he was released on bail. Mr. Singh was released on interim bail on Tuesday

and was declared the Kolkata Port candidate. The Kolkata police had arrested him in an alleged extortion case. With the sixth and last list published on Wednesday, the BJP has finalised its candidates for all the 294 Assembly constituencies. “He [Firhad Hakim] has been an MLA of 15 years. He has monopolised the area... If you choose your beta (son) Rakesh Singh and not neta (politician), then I will introduce buses and build hospitals here,” Mr. Singh said.



Strongman Rakesh Singh is the BJP's candidate for Kolkata Port constituency. PTI

‘Trinamool govt. snatched land of Bengal people’

▼ BJP chief Nitin Nabin on Wednesday alleged the Mamata Banerjee-led government snatched the land which rightfully belongs to West Bengal's people and gave it to infiltrators, changing the State's demography. Addressing an election rally in Alipurduar in north

Bengal, Mr. Nabin said once the BJP forms a “double-engine” government in the State, it will rectify the demographic alterations and throw out Bangladeshi infiltrators from the State. The residents of Bengal were being “forced” to leave the State owing to the Trinamool Congress's appeasement politics and lawlessness, the BJP chief alleged. He also asserted that the State has a special place in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's heart. PTI



●● This election is not just about changing the govt. but about eradicating violence, corruption and hatred. CM of Assam is the most corrupt CM RAHUL GANDHI LoP in Lok Sabha

PM to address three rallies in Bengal today

▼ Prime Minister Narendra Modi will intensify the BJP's poll campaign on Thursday with rallies in Haldia, Asansol and Siuri. The choice of venues underlines BJP's attempt to consolidate its support in areas where it has made gains while pushing into regions considered strongholds of the Trinamool Congress. PTI



●● Telangana is financially bankrupt and drowning in corruption. And still, he [A. Revanth Reddy] mocked Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi DASOJU SRAVAN Bharat Rashtra Samithi MLC



Poll formalities: Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee was re-elected from Bhabanipur in a 2021 byelection by a record margin of 58,832 votes. DEBASISH BHADURI

Stage set for a keen contest, as Mamata files papers from Bhabanipur

Shrabana Chatterjee KOLKATA

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee filed her nomination as the Trinamool Congress candidate for the high-stakes Bhabanipur constituency on Wednesday morning. The Trinamool chairperson is seeking a fourth term against a formidable challenge from the Opposition. Ms. Banerjee won the Bhabanipur seat for the past three consecutive terms, starting in 2011, when her party had a historic win, which ended the 34-year Left rule in West Bengal.

With party workers crowding both sides of the road, Ms. Banerjee walked to the Alipur Survey building from her house in Kolkata. She was accompanied by her close confidant and Kolkata Mayor, Firhad Hakim.

“I am doing this with a heavy heart, so many people have been removed from the final voter list. What is the point of adding names later? The Supreme Court had said that all legitimate voters would get a chance to appeal before tribunals. We will go again and seek justice once more,” the Trinamool chief said after she officially filed her nomination. This came as a response to the names of 27 lakh under-adjudication voters being deleted from the final voter list on Tuesday.

Ms. Banerjee said that she had been in Bhabanipur since her childhood and that the constituency had been central to her life. She urged the people of West Bengal to vote for Trinamool candidates in all 294 seats, asserting that the party would form the government after the election was over.

High-profile contest

The high-profile Bhabanipur contest is keenly watched as the Leader of the Opposition and Bharatiya Janata Party heavyweight, Suvendu Adhikari, is contesting the seat. Union Home Minister Amit Shah himself campaigned for Mr. Adhikari when the latter filed his nomination for the Bhabanipur seat last week. A stand-off unfolded near the CM's residence, as Trinamool and BJP workers faced off, triggering tensions and prompting police intervention to restore order.

In 2021, Ms. Banerjee contested against Mr. Adhikari from Nandigram and lost by a margin of 1,956 votes. However, she was re-elected from Bhabanipur in a byelection by a record margin of 58,832 votes.

While on the campaign trail, Mr. Adhikari has on multiple occasions stated that he would now defeat Ms. Banerjee from her home constituency, as he had in Nandigram in the previous term. Meanwhile, Ms. Banerjee has expressed confidence and has said that she would win from Bhabanipur even if only one voter was left.

Responding to Ms. Banerjee filing her nomination, Mr. Adhikari on Wednesday said that he would defeat the Chief Minister for a second time. “She and her party both will lose this time,” the BJP leader said. After May 4, they would bring justice for all the wrongdoings of the Mamata Banerjee-led government, he added.

Later in the day, she held three campaign rallies. From one of her rallies, Ms. Banerjee said that the BJP's days in Bengal were numbered. “They have deleted voters from all communities. They [BJP] are forgetting that when the fire spreads, all communities will be affected,” Ms. Banerjee added.

EPS, the lone star of AIADMK election campaign, steps up his pitch for power

The former Chief Minister is the main campaigner for the AIADMK across Tamil Nadu, with a stump speech focused on law and order issues, the State's finances, concerns of government employees, drug menace, and rising inflation; he also highlights features of the manifesto of his party

CAMPAIGN TRAIL

T. Ramakrishnan CHENNAI

All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami does not have a glamour quotient like his predecessors M.G. Ramachandran and Jayalithaa, or even the founder of the fledgling Tamilaga Vetttri Kazhagam (TVK), C. Joseph Vijay. Neither does he possess the famed oratorical skills of former Chief Minister and Dravidian doyen M. Karunanidhi.

Yet, ever since Mr. Palaniswami occupied the seat of Chief Minister and became the driving force of his party in February 2017, he has become known for his conviction and the effective articulation of his views.

He often addresses people and the press without any script or teleprompter, only consulting notes as needed, as he did on Wednesday, while campaigning in Chennai.

He launched his campaign on March 25 after of

fering prayers at the Kapaleswarar temple in Mylapore, a south Chennai constituency with a large number of educated voters, seeking votes in support of Tamilisai Soundararajan, the nominee of the Bharatiya Janata Party, an ally of the AIADMK.

Solo responsibility

EPS, as he is popularly known, bears almost the entire responsibility of his party's State-wide campaign, unlike in the rival Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam where Chief Minister M.K. Stalin shares duties with his son and Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin.

In the 2021 campaign, EPS had support from O. Panneerselvam, another former Chief Minister and then-coordinator of the party. But the duo have fallen apart, and OPS is now in the fray as the DMK's nominee in his familiar terrain of Bodinayakkannur in the southern Theni district. Of course, leaders of the AIADMK's allies also chip in, but their coverage has only limited reach.

Mr. Palaniswami, who addresses people on the campaign trail standing on



In the spotlight: AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami addressing an election campaign in Tiruvannamalai district on April 4. C. VENKATCHALAPATHY

a specially made multi-seater vehicle, prominently wears a sticker bearing his party's “two leaves” symbol. The first part of his stump speech is devoted to attacking the ruling DMK. Crimes against women, “deteriorating” law and order, the prevalence of drugs, and the “worsening” finances of the State government are some of

the issues that have repeatedly figured in his speeches for the past few years.

The AIADMK leader makes it a point to cover issues concerning government employees and pensioners. Resuming his campaign in Chennai's Velachery on Wednesday morning – this time, near the Pallava-era Dhandeeswarar temple – for his par-

ty's nominee and former legislator, M.K. Ashok, Mr. Palaniswami talked about how many people have retired from government service in the past five years and how many were recruited, pointing to the net reduction in staff strength.

At this point in his speech, he usually brings up the DMK's 2021 poll promise to restore the Old Pension

Scheme, slamming the ruling party's failure to keep its word.

Inflation is one of the core themes of his speech, and Mr. Palaniswami often compares the prices of essential commodities during the previous AIADMK reign and the present DMK regime. He also details how tax rates and user charges have shot up in the past five years. Using these two reasons, he justifies his party's promise to make a one-time payment of ₹10,000 to the State's women as a form of “relief”.

Mr. Palaniswami also highlights features of the party manifesto, including the free distribution of refrigerators, three free refills of cooking gas cylinders per year, and the extension of the free bus travel scheme to men.

Before leaving for his next campaign stop, Mr. Palaniswami briefly engages the audience, raising slogans such as “*Makkalai Kappom, Tamizhagathai Meetpom* (Let us protect the people, reclaim Tamil Nadu)”, and “*Stalin Model Arasu, Failure Model Arasu* (Stalin's governance model is a failed model)”.

Promise of jobs remains big highlight of poll manifestos of Left Front and Congress

The Hindu Bureau KOLKATA

The promise of jobs, especially for youth, is a highlight in the manifestos of both the Communist Party of India (Marxist)-led Left Front and the Congress, ahead of the West Bengal Assembly election.

While the Left Front manifesto released on Saturday promised one permanent job for every family, the Congress, which announced its manifesto on Tuesday, vowed that all vacant government posts will be filled in the first Cabinet meeting if the party comes to power.

The 15-page manifesto of the Left Front sought to focus on key issues instead of ‘mandir-masjid’ politics. The Left Front will provide a 100-day job guarantee for poor people living in urban areas, and 200 days job guarantee for the poor in rural Bengal, the alliance chairman Biman Bose said.

The Congress manifesto, which was released by party president Mallikarjun Kharge, mentioned the Yuva Samman, under which the party has promised funding for start-ups and establishment of AI centres as well.

Jobs are an important issue in the 2026 Assembly election, and Union Home Minister Amit Shah has announced that if his party is



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Left Front Chairman Biman Bose releasing the manifestos of their parties in Bengal. PTI

elected to power, it will implement the Seventh Pay Commission for State government employees. Mr. Shah has also promised an age relaxation for candidates who lost out because of the “corruption of the Trinamool Congress” in giving jobs to the people of the State.

Cash incentives

West Bengal has been grappling with the migration of a million workers from the State, largely seeking jobs. Just before the polls were announced, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee announced the Banglar Yuva Sathi scheme to provide ₹1,500 per month to unemployed youth between 20 and 40 years of age. About 80 lakh youth have filled the form to receive monthly entitlements. The West Bengal ruling party's manifesto, called “*Didi's Ten Promises*”, speaks about

cash incentive schemes but remains silent on jobs.

The Left Front also promised initiatives for heavy and medium scale industrialisation, and vowed to set up new software and hardware parks.

The Congress manifesto, which announces ‘Five guarantees for West Bengal’, looks like a copy of the Trinamool Congress's poll promises. While the Trinamool is putting its faith in its Lakshmir Bhandar scheme, under which ₹1,500 per month is given to every woman, the Congress has promised to implement Durga Samman, offering women a ₹2,000 payout each month.

Another Congress scheme which appears to be a mirror image of a Trinamool promise is the Bidhan Swastha Suraksha, which promises health insurance for every family up to ₹10 lakh.

The Hindu Bureau NEW DELHI

Congress leader Pawan Khera on Wednesday moved the Telangana High Court seeking anticipatory bail in a case filed in Guwahati in connection with his allegations against Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife.

The leader, who showed his residential address in Hyderabad, requested the court to release him on bail in the event of his arrest. Mr. Khera's wife hails from Telangana and he has a residence in Hyderabad. The State is ruled by the Congress. The petition will be taken up on Thursday morning.

In his petition for anticipatory bail, Mr. Khera has pleaded that he is a law-abiding citizen, has no criminal antecedents and holds a responsible position in the principal opposition party. The Congress leader said he is ready to cooperate in the case against him and hence be given pre-arrest bail.

Mr. Khera accused Mr. Sarma of “unleashing” the State police on him, instead of responding to questions raised by the Opposition over alleged foreign investments and multiple passports linked to the latter's wife.

The Congress leader's charge came after a team



The Assam Police and Delhi Police coming out of Congress leader Pawan Khera's residence in New Delhi on Tuesday. ANI

of Assam Police landed in Delhi on Tuesday and searched his flat in the Nizamuddin area of Delhi.

Complaint filed

The police action followed a criminal complaint by Mr. Sarma's entrepreneur wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, alleging that the Congress had used forged and fake documents to target her. The case was registered in the Guwahati Crime Branch Police Station against Mr. Khera under several sections of the BNS, including 175 (false statement in connection with an election), 35 (Right of private defence of the body and of property) and 318 (cheating).

In a recorded video message from an undisclosed location, Mr. Khera said the Congress had only sought answers and would continue to do so. “Scaring others may be your habit,

but getting scared is not ours,” he said, adding that he was avoiding the police because he had “more questions to ask”.

The Congress leader reiterated allegations relating to a purported company in Wyoming in the United States linked to Ms. Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, claiming the firm listed addresses in London, Dubai, and Dhaka. He also alleged links to another entity registered in the United Kingdom, and referred to earlier claims about multiple foreign passports and a UAE ‘golden visa’.

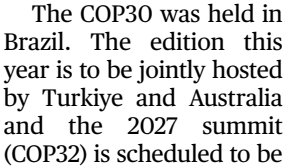
“Once again, through him (Mr. Khera), they have released another set of completely fabricated documents – already exposed by our team. This is not politics any more. This is outright deception,” Mr. Sarma said in a post on social media platform X. (With PTI inputs)

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday said that “action is necessary in view of the highly derogatory, inflammatory, and communal tweets” posted by journalist Rana Ayyub between 2013-2017. Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav, hearing the plea alleging that Ms. Ayyub’s tweets insulted Hindu deities and “reversed historical figures”, noted that an FIR had also been against her over her tweets. “The matter requires urgent consideration”, the court said, while posting the case for hearing on Friday. The court also issued notice to Ms. Ayyub as well as social media platform X on the plea seeking the immediate removal of the tweets posted by her.

In the letter, the academics called the court's intervention in the issue "a case of judicial overreach." "Since, in India, a book can be banned only by law, the Supreme Court overreached its powers in banning the textbook," it said.

"We feel concerned that the Supreme Court's ban on the book has prevented educational experts, teachers and other stakeholders from objectively examining the contentious chapter," the letter further stated.

In July 2025, the Envi-



On March 25, India announced its updated Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs), committing by 2035 to source 60% of its installed electricity capacity from non-fossil sources, reduce emissions intensity of GDP by 47%, and increase its carbon sink by 3.5-4 billion tonnes of CO₂ equivalent.

Comprehensive review
“The discussions focused on areas such as trade and investments, tourism, technology and innovation, energy, cooperation in educational and cultural fields, people to people ties, and fight against cross-border terrorism,” the Ministry of External Affairs said in a statement, refer-

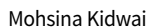
Former Indian diplomats also said the development reflected a more realistic approach to relations. "In an era of growing global disorder, India-Türkiye talks reflect a pragmatic effort to manage differences and keep lines of communication open," said Vikas Swarup, who retired as Secretary (West) in the MEA (2019-2021) and had served in the Embassy at Ankara.

While rock-cut cisterns have been found earlier on the Elephanta Island, the discovery of this stepped reservoir was important because it was a carefully designed architecture for

The excavation has so far yielded a beautifully built brick structure, which could be a dyeing vat for colouring textiles, a big storage pot, terracotta figurines, glass and stone bangles, beads made of carnelian and quartz and stone anchors. A total of about 3,000 amphorae sherds of Mediterranean

The identification was made on the basis of the motif of a seated bull on the obverse and a temple symbol with the legend of Sri Krishnaraja on the reverse, he said.

Congress president Mal-
likarjun Kharge, in a post



Ms. Kidwai held several Union government portfolios, including Labour, Health and Family Welfare, Rural Development, Transport, and Urban Development. Her political journey began in 1960 when she was elected to the Uttar Pradesh Legislative Council at the age of 28. She later became a Minister in the State government and entered national politics after winning the 1978 by-election from Azamgarh.

FAITH

Murugan is known as Guha

One of Lord Murugan's names is Guha, said So.So. Mee-nakshisundaram in a discourse. An old man had three sons, all of whom were married and had one child each. One day all the three infants cried at the same time. Alarmed, the old man asked his daughters-in-law why the babies were crying. The first one said the child had wet itself, and now that she had changed the napkin, the baby would soon stop crying. The second daughter-in-law said her child was afraid of darkness. She had lit a lamp in the room, and so the child would no longer be afraid. The third daughter-in-law said her child did not like being left alone. She had picked him up and had placed him on her lap. So he too would stop crying.

So we can infer that most babies do not like lying on a wet surface or darkness and they do not like being alone. And yet, these three are unavoidable until a baby is born into this world. The mother's womb is dark; the child there cannot avoid water; and the child is alone too. So how does the child cope in these uncomfortable surroundings? It manages, because it isn't really alone. There is a deity inside, who stays guard. That deity is Murugan, also known as Guha. Guha means cave. Because Murugan is beside every baby in the dark, cavernous womb of a mother, He is known as Guha. Guha guards the baby, and talks with it. He makes it clear to the baby that He will stay beside him/her only so long as he or she is in the mother's womb. Once the baby is born, Murugan no longer stays beside the infant. But He comes the moment He is called. There is no limit to Murugan's prowess. He is the embodiment of limitless bliss. He is omniscient.

INBRIEF



NTPC inks MoU with Électricité de France

State-owned National Thermal Power Corp Ltd. (NTPC) said it had inked a non-binding memorandum of understanding (MoU) with French counterpart Électricité de France (EDF) to explore opportunities in India's nuclear power space. According to a statement, the two entities would seek to establish a framework for jointly assessing “feasibility and approach for collaboration”. NTPC is targeting to institute 30 GW of nuclear capacity by 2047.

IRDAI issues revised cybersecurity guidelines

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority (IRDAI) has issued revised guidelines on information and cybersecurity. The guidelines are intended to enable the insurance industry further strengthen their defences as well as related governance mechanisms to deal with emerging cyberthreats, IRDAI said in a communication addressed to all insurers, insurance intermediaries and the Insurance Information Bureau (IIB).

Cyient Semiconductors buys 74% in Kinetic Tech for \$85 mn

Cyient Semiconductors has acquired 74% stake in power semiconductor solutions provider Kinetic Technologies for \$85 million. The investment reflects a broader strategic shift toward building a differentiated, custom silicon and ASSP-led semiconductor platform aligned with long-term structural demand in power and compute infrastructure, addressing a \$44 billion global market opportunity, Cyient Semiconductors said in a release.

West Asia crisis: Centre increases fertilizer sop for kharif season

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Amid concerns of a possible rise in fertilizer prices on account of the situation in West Asia, the Union Cabinet here approved an increase of about 12% in nutrient-based subsidy for Phosphatic and Potassic (P&K) fertilizers for the on-going kharif crop season. Effective April 1 and up

to September 30 this year, the tentative budgetary need for the subsidy would be ₹41,533.81 crore. “This is approximately ₹4,317 crore more than the budgetary requirement for kharif 2025 season. The budget for kharif 2025 was ₹37,216.15 crore,” the Union Government said. The Government maintained by increasing the subsidy, the availability of

fertilizers to farmers at subsidised, affordable and reasonable prices will be ensured. The move will also result in the rationalisation of subsidy on P&K fertilizers due to recent trends in global prices of fertilizers and inputs. The Centre is now making available 28 grades of P&K fertilizers to farmers at subsidised rates through fertilizer firms/importers.

Shippers seek clarity as Iran still controls strait of Hormuz

M. Kalyanaraman
Debayan Tewari
CHENNAI

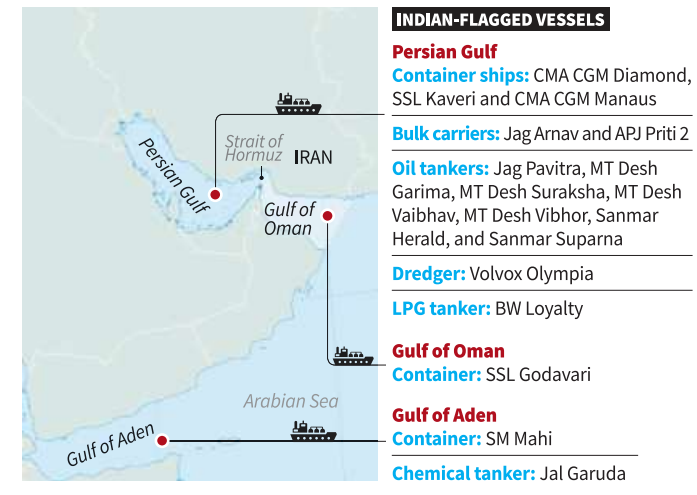
On Day 1 of ceasefire, nearly 10 vessel exits through the Strait of Hormuz have been reported by Rystad Energy, a Norway-based energy research firm. Of these, four are likely “dark” Iranian tankers, two are bulk carriers and one is a mid-size tanker. “Looking ahead, there is little expectation flows will normalise in the near term,” says Erik Grundt, Senior Data Analyst at Rystad Energy. While ship owners and charterers were preparing for a quick exit, they were also awaiting more clarity on the terms and conditions for transit given the indications that Iran still exercises de-facto control over the strait.

Technical limitations Iran says safe passage will involve its armed forces and there are “technical limitations” though the U.S. President has talked about “complete, immediate safe opening.” Secretary-General of the International Maritime

Organization, Arsenio Dominguez, has said that he is working with relevant parties to implement an appropriate mechanism to ensure the safe transit of ships through the strait. Hundreds of ships are stranded west of the Persian Gulf, fearing attacks and damage to cargo, vessel structure and lives of seafarers. Among them were some 35 ships, either Indian-flagged or foreign flagged carrying cargo for India, three weeks into the war. Nearly 22 energy-critical vessels were marked for evacuation with Indian naval assistance. This included three LNG carriers, 12 LPG carriers and seven crude oil tankers. Eight Indian flagged LPG carriers have crossed the strait and come to India since then. “Though ceasefire has been announced, we are waiting for clearance from Indian government before our ships will move. We understand that we are bringing supplies essential for the everyday lives of Indians. But the safety of our ships and lives of seafarers onboard are at stake,” says a source among shipowners. He adds the war risk

Homebound now

Some 25 Indian-flagged vessels and foreign-flagged ships bound for India are stranded in the Persian Gulf region due to the West Asia conflict



premiums are several times higher for moving ships, so, choosing to move now is also a commercial decision. “We would like relief from government in terms of supporting our war risk insurance payments,” he says. Before the war started, while Iran and Oman had territorial waters falling in the strait, no country controlled the transit of ships that was free. A few weeks into the war, Lloyd’s List

reported Iran had put in place a system for approving ship transits that could have involved payments. There was a process and ships had to hug the Iranian coast and go around the Iranian Larak Island for visual approval as well. Transits, which had trickled to a handful following the start of war, then rose to 10% of pre-war levels in April, though many of them were Iran-linked. “As far as shipowners

are concerned, it is still Iran that remains in effective control of the strait and permission will need to be sought from the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps,” says Richard Meade, editor-in-chief of Lloyd’s List. Jakob Larsen, chief safety and security officer, of BIMCO, an international organisation representing shipowners, charterers and agents, says that the shipping industry is cur-

India-bound foreign-flagged ships

LPG: Symi, DV Sarv Shakti (Marshall Islands), Gaschem Erica (Portugal)
Oil tankers: Plata Carrier (Liberia), Minerva Doxa (Greece), Nissos Keros (Marshall Islands), Monte Urbasa (Portugal)
LNG: Disha (Malta)
ALREADY BACK IN INDIA
LPG: Shivalik, Nanda Devi, Jag Vasant, Pine Gas, Green Asha, Green Sanvi, BW Elm & Tyr
Bulker: Vishva Nidhi
Container: CMA CGM Vittoria

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

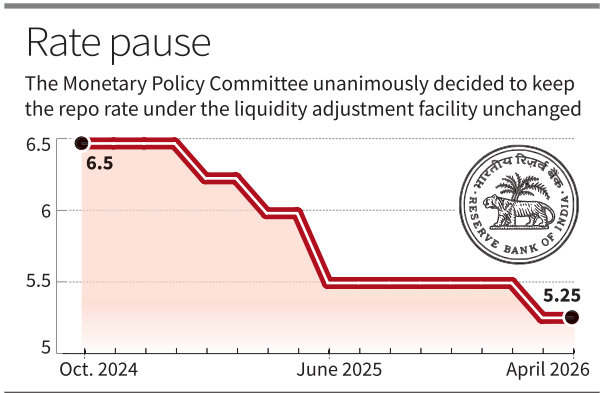
In a boost to hydro-electric power in Arunachal Pradesh, the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs approved an investment of ₹26,069.5 crore in the construction of Kamala Hydro Electric project alongside a sum of ₹14,105.83 crore to build the Kalai-II hydro-electric project.

The Kamala Hydro-electric project would account for a total installed capacity of 1,720 megawatts and expected to generate 6,870 million units of energy a year. It spans Kamle, Kra Daadi and Kurung Kumey districts of the State. The Kalai-II hydro-electric project, would have an installed capacity of 1,200 MW and generate 4,852.95 million units annually.

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Hours after Donald Trump announced on social media about the conditional temporary ceasefire in West Asia, the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) unanimously voted to hold the repo rate at 5.25%. It also decided to continue with the neutral stance. Later, addressing a press conference, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra said that the ceasefire, to some extent, has been taken into account in the monetary policy decision.

Low interest rates Mr. Malhotra said despite the impact of the war in West Asia, there was a possibility of having low inter-



est rates in the short to medium term in India. Stating that the West Asia conflict would impede growth, the MPC opined that the intensity and the duration of the conflict and the resultant damage to the energy and other infrastructure added risk to the inflation and growth outlooks. The economy is con-

fronted with a supply shock, it emphasised. Going forward, elevated energy and other commodity prices, as also shocks to availability of inputs due to disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz, were likely to impact growth in 2026-27, it added. Taking various factors into consideration, the real GDP growth forecast for

2026-27 has been reduced by 70 bps to 6.9%. And the CPI inflation for 2026-27 had been projected a tad higher at 4.5% from 4.4% earlier. The RBI has factored in crude price at \$85 a barrel in the inflation forecast for this year and \$75 for next year. Stating that the global economic conditions and sentiment had soured after the outbreak of the West Asia conflict, the MPC said these had adversely impacted the growth-inflation outlook. The MPC noted that geopolitical uncertainties had heightened significantly and the upside risks to the inflation outlook, driven by increased energy price pressures and probable weather disturbances affecting food prices, had increased.

Cabinet panel okays 84% hike to HPCL project cost

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

To provide a boost to domestic petrochemicals production, the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) on Wednesday approved an 84% increase in the project cost of HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Ltd. from ₹43,129 crore to ₹79,459 crore.

Further, HPCL would pump in an additional equity investment of ₹8,962 crore, thus bringing the total equity investment after the increment to 19,600 crore. The project is a joint venture between HPCL and the Government of Rajasthan, with the latter holding an equity stake of 26%.

Indices surge 4%, see ‘best day in five years

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Benchmark Nifty 50 and Sensex rose almost 4% on Wednesday, their best day in a single session in five years after crude prices saw the first huge decline on April 8. Nifty 50 and Sensex opened at 23,855.15 and 77,290.6, and kept up the

momentum for the better part of the day before closing at 23,997 points and 77,562.9 points respectively. The benchmark indices are thus inching closer to pre-war levels. The rally comes on top of a low base of March, when markets dipped over 11%. All sectoral indices improved and 278 stocks hit the upper circuit.

Elevated crude prices to increase imported inflation, widen CAD: Malhotra

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Despite the unprecedented geopolitical disturbances in West Asia and supply chain disruptions as well as its resultant impact on the global economy, Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra on Wednesday said the fundamentals of the Indian economy remained on a stronger footing at the current juncture than in previous crisis episodes, providing it with ‘greater resilience to withstand shocks’. However, Mr. Malhotra noted that elevated crude oil prices could increase imported inflation and widen the current account deficit. He said the disruptions in energy markets, fertilisers and other commodities may adversely impact industry, agriculture and services, reducing domestic output. “The heightened uncertainty, increased risk aversion and safe haven demand could impact domestic liquidity conditions, economic activity, consumption and investment and weaker global growth prospects may dampen external demand and reduce remittance flows and adverse spillovers from global financial markets could tighten domestic financial conditions and raise the cost of borrowing,” he said. Overall, the initial supply shock can potentially



Sanjay Malhotra

transform into a demand shock over the medium term if the restoration of supply chains is delayed, he emphasised. To a question on the impact on remittances, RBI Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta said, “Our remittances come from diverse jurisdictions in which the share of the Gulf countries have declined over time. If you look at the last 10 to 15 years data they [remittances from all geographies] have moved in the upward direction. So we are not anticipating any dip to the remittances because it [the war going by the social media post] is going to be resolved soon.” “We anticipate that the demand for migrant workers will infact increase from this [Gulf] region which will help the remittances,” she added. She said besides geographical diversity, remittances are coming from a diverse skill pool which includes low-skilled, mid-skilled and high-skilled migrant workers across countries.

Govt. extends bulk commercial LPG allocation to more sectors

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Expanding the availability and supply of liquified petroleum gas (LPG) to industrial sectors, the Petroleum Ministry, in a communication to States, sought that industrial units in pharma, agriculture, uranium, metal, ceramic, foundry and aerosol, among other sectors, receive 70% of bulk

non-domestic LPG based on the consumption assessed pre-March this year. Earlier, the industrial beneficiaries of commercial LPG allocation included steel, plastics, food industry and chemical sectors, among others. This would, however, be subject to an overall sectoral limit of 0.2 thousand metric tonne (TMT)/day. The communication

emphasised priority be given to units where LPG is required for specialised purposes. Though the latest communication also seeks a transition to piped natural gas (PNG) to avail bulk LPG allocation, it accords an exception for industries where LPG serves specialised purposes in the manufacturing process and PNG may not serve as an adequate substitute.

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FRONTLINE

LEADING THE DEBATE SINCE 1981

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Dtd:01.04.2026
e-Tender-cum-e-Auction Notice
An e-Tender-cum-e-Auction Notice invites bids for "Allotment of 2 nos. patches of Port land about 25 acres each for handling of Containers along with Dry Bulk & Break Bulk Cargo on long term lease basis for a period of 30 years" is available in the website from 01.04.2026 to 21.04.2026. For details, interested bidders may log on the website <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>.
Sr.Dy.Secretary,
Paradip Port Authority
PPA/PR/03/2026-2027, dt.07/04/2026

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TID-40021(31)/1/2026-PRO SEC(Adv.No.08) Date:08-04-2026
EXECUTIVE OFFICER

THE HUTTI GOLD MINES COMPANY LIMITED
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
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e-Mail: material276339@gmail.com website: www.huttigold.karnataka.gov.in
T.NO.42/25-26 No.HGML/2025-26/PREQUAL_TENDER_NUMBER_3
Date: 09.04.2026

Tender Notification: Invitation for Expression of Interest (EOI)
Expression of Interest (EOI) for empanelment of Chartered Accountant/Cost Accountant firms.
Interested consultant/consultancy, firm/individual consultants shall visit the link <https://www.kppp.karnataka.gov.in> for necessary details like General conditions, eligibility criteria, etc., The interested agencies need to register with KPPP Portal GoK, for participating in EOI.
SCHEDULE OF EVENTS : Pre-bid meeting (Zoom) : **15.04.2026 at 11.00 AM**. Last date for receipt of Bid : **25.04.2026 at 4.00 PM**. Date & Time for Opening of EOI Bid : **27.04.2026 at 10.00 AM**.
Sd/- I/c. Dy. General Manager (Materials)
LEADING GOLD PRODUCER IN INDIA

MARKING HIS RUN-UP

Cameron gets the green signal to start bowling for Knight Riders



REUTERS

Australian all-rounder Cameron Green may finally be seen bowling for Kolkata Knight Riders in IPL 2026 when the three-time champion faces Lucknow Super Giants in Kolkata on Thursday, providing a boost to its depleted bowling stock. On the eve of the match, Green spent over 30 minutes at the nets, bowling with full intent.

RAIN WOES

Inclement weather cuts short KKR and LSG practice sessions



R.V. MOORTHY

Kolkata Knight Riders and Lucknow Super Giants players had to wrap up their practice sessions much earlier than schedule due to rain and strong winds at Eden Gardens on Wednesday. After KKR's second IPL 2026 home match against Punjab Kings was washed out, the Ajinkya Rahane-led team will take on LSG on Thursday.

DEADLY COMBO

Jaiswal-Suryavanshi duo is the best going around, feels Parag



AP

Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag described Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Suryavanshi as "the best going around" and "number one" among opening pairs in IPL 2026. "They have got age on their side. Vaibhav is incredible and Jaiswal has been doing it for a few years now. They have the skills and maturity".

PLAYING IT SAFE

Santner rested against Royals as a precaution, reveals Jayawardene



PTI

Mumbai Indians head coach Mahela Jayawardene said that left-arm spinner Mitchell Santner was rested against Rajasthan Royals as a precaution. "Mitch had a niggle when he came off in the last game. So, it was a precaution; he wasn't 100% to play this game. But hopefully, he'll be fit for our next game," said Jayawardene.

Miller goes from hero to villain as Titans win thriller

The southpaw's decision to not take a run off the penultimate ball proves costly as DC suffers a one-run loss; Rahul's effort in vain; Gill, Buttler, Washington shine with the bat while Rashid scalps three

IPL-19

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

High tension permeated the cool air at the Arun Jaitley Stadium here on Wednesday as Delhi Capitals and Gujarat Titans engaged in a high-scoring cliffhanger in the Indian Premier League.

Twists and turns unfolded at breakneck speed, with Shubman Gill's Titans prevailing by one run in the end. In response to GT's 210 for four, DC finished on 209 for eight.

With two runs required off the final ball, David Miller swung hard at a short ball by Prasidh Krishna. But the southpaw failed to make contact, and as he and Kuldeep Yadav scampered for a single, the latter was found short at the striker's end after wicket-keeper Jos Buttler hit the stumps.

Off the penultimate ball, Miller had pulled Prasidh towards fine-leg and had an easy run on offer, but he chose to stay at his end and face the final delivery. The South African may rue that decision in hindsight.

For GT, leg-spinner Rashid Khan was sensa-



Show-stoppers: Gill returned to the side in style while Buttler and Rahul were back in form in a high-scoring game. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

tional with figures of 4-0-17-3. Gill, Buttler and Washington Sundar also played their roles with fine half-centuries earlier in the evening. That DC came this close was down to K.L. Rahul's 92 and Miller's late

heroics. The host appeared to have run out of steam with 36 runs to get off the last two overs and four wickets in hand. But Miller, having retired hurt at the start of the 14th over due to a hand injury before com-

ing back in the 17th, hadn't resigned to that idea.

He walloped Mohammed Siraj for two sixes and a four in the penultimate over, whittling down the requirement to 13 off six balls. In a game where



runs were aplenty, Rashid lent a decisive hand with crucial strikes.

The ace leggie had Nitish Rana caught at long-off, thanks to an excellent grab by B. Sai Sudharsan in the 10th over, and then

cleaned up the in-form Sameer Rizvi with a masterful wrong 'un. A little later, Axar Patel became Rashid's third victim on the night. It eventually condemned DC to defeat by the narrowest of margins.



Cliffhanger: The Titans players kept their cool to post their first win of the season. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

SCOREBOARD

GUJARAT TITANS

B. Sai Sudharsan b Mukesh 12 (7b, 2x4), Shubman Gill c Nitish Rana b Ngidi 70 (45b, 4x4, 5x6), Jos Buttler b Kuldeep 52 (27b, 3x4, 5x6), Washington Sundar c Nitish Rana b Mukesh 55 (32b, 6x4, 2x6), Glenn Phillips (not out) 14 (9b, 1x4, 1x6), Rahul Tewatia (not out) 1 (1b); Extras (nb-1, w-5): 6; Total (for four wkts. in 20 overs): 210.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-19 (Sai Sudharsan, 2.1 overs), 2-79 (Buttler, 7.3), 3-183 (Gill, 17.3), 4-205 (Washington, 19.3).

CAPITALS BOWLING

Mukesh 4-0-55-2, Ngidi 4-0-24-1, Axar 3-0-32-0, Kuldeep 4-0-42-1, Natarajan 4-0-34-0, Vipraj 1-0-23-0.

DELHI CAPITALS

Pathum Nissanka c Tewatia b Prasidh 41 (24b, 6x4, 1x6), K.L. Rahul c Buttler b Siraj 92 (52b, 11x4, 4x6), Nitish Rana c Sai Sudharsan b Rashid 5 (6b, 1x4), Sameer Rizvi (Impact Player for Mukesh) b Rashid 0 (1b), David

Miller (not out) 41 (19b, 3x4, 3x6), Axar Patel c Phillips b Rashid 2 (3b), Tristan Stubbs run out 7 (6b), Vipraj Nigam c Gill b Prasidh 12 (7b, 2x4), Kuldeep Yadav run out 1 (1b); Extras (w-8): 8; Total (for eight wkts. in 20 overs): 209.

FALL OF WICKETS

1-76 (Nissanka, 8.1), 2-101 (Nitish, 9.5), 3-101 (Rizvi, 9.6), 4-134 (Axar, 13.6), 5-160 (Stubbs, 16.4), 6-166 (Rahul, 16.6), 7-202 (Vipraj, 19.2), 8-209 (Kuldeep, 19.6).

TITANS BOWLING

Siraj 4-0-52-1, Rabada 4-0-32-0, Rashid 4-0-17-3, Ashok 3-0-45-0, Prasidh (Impact Player for Shahrulkh) 4-0-52-2, Washington 1-0-11-0.

Toss: DC; PoM: Rashid. Titans won by one run.

Next assignment

DC: April 11 vs. CSK Chennai, 7.30 p.m.

GT: April 12 vs. LSG Lucknow, 3.30 p.m.

Brevis hints he could play against DC

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Chennai Super Kings is likely to get a boost ahead of its next match against Delhi Capitals on April 11, with middle-order batter Dewald Brevis all set to be fit for the crucial fixture.

The South African batter hinted that he has recovered from a side strain during a sponsor event on Wednesday. "I can't wait to see you on the 11th, every match everywhere we play," he said when asked to give a message to the CSK fans.

Meanwhile, M.S. Dhoni, who is recovering from a calf strain in the city, is unlikely to feature on Saturday. The 44-year-old, though, trained in Chennai before the team's first home fixture against the Punjab Kings last week.



Brevis. R. RAGU

KKR eyes first victory as LSG comes calling

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

Three-time champion Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) has experienced its worst-ever start to an Indian Premier League (IPL) season after three matches and would like to record its first win in 2026 against Lucknow Super Giants (LSG) at the Eden Gardens here on Thursday.

A season expected to pose a problem of plenty has turned out to be one with plenty of problems for the Ajinkya Rahane-led side, which is struggling to find the right bowling combination due to injuries to its key pacers and the lacklustre performance of its reliable spinners.

Without consistency in its batting, barring young Angkrish Raghuvanshi, KKR has found itself in a soup. Following two losses and a point from the washed-out match against Punjab Kings, KKR would look to overcome the odds.

Top wicket-taker Blessing Muzarabani should lead the attack with support from Vaibhav Arora and Kartik Tyagi. Sunil Narine, who recovered from his abdominal pain and trained on Wednesday, looked set to return, while there were doubts over an



Back in the mix: Narine is expected to return for KKR. R.V. MOORTHY

Today's match



Kolkata, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 6

KKR 2 | LSG 4

PREVIOUS MEETING

LSG won by four runs, 2025

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIHOOTSTAR

injured Chakaravarthy.

In batting, Rahane, Finn Allen, and Rinku Singh need to shoulder the responsibility, while the team will be keen to see its Aussie import Cameron Green getting back his touch.

While KKR will be eager to get off the blocks, LSG,

at its owner Sanjiv Goenka's home city, would like to carry forward its momentum after defeating Sunrisers Hyderabad.

LSG, studded with capable batters including captain Rishabh Pant, Aiden Markram, Mitchell Marsh, and Nicholas Pooran, will look to capitalise on KKR's unsettled attack.

A resurgent Mohammed Shami on his 'home' ground, the effective Prince Yadav, Mohsin Khan, Avesh Khan, wily spinner Digvesh Rathi, and another 'home' boy Shahbaz Ahmed are capable of disturbing any batting line-up.

With both sides hoping to outsmart each other, LSG is likely to enjoy some advantage because of its effective bowling.

I have benefitted from Bravo's inputs: Tyagi

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

Young Kolkata Knight Riders pacer Kartik Tyagi on Wednesday said he received a lot of help from team mentor Dwayne Bravo with regard to implementation of skills in match situations.

On the eve of KKR's match against Lucknow Super Giants, Tyagi said, "Everyone knows about one's skill set. Sometimes you make plans but when you are under pressure and you are playing after a long time, then you are not able to think properly. At such a time, when you have so much experience outside, that helps us a lot on the ground."

The 25-year-old said he was aware that several key pacers of KKR would not

be available due to injuries and he might get chances to play. "Long before, everyone knew that Harshit (Rana) bhai was injured. And there was a scene of (Matheesha) Pathirana being injured. So we prepared (accordingly)."

Tyagi, who got a chance to play in the IPL after taking 11 wickets in the 2020 under-19 World Cup but struggled with fitness issues later, said he worked on his fitness and bowling.

"When I was in Sunrisers, Dale Steyn was there. I was having an injury-related problem. A shin splints issue was not getting sorted. I went to the physio, who has been with me from my under-16 days, and did the treatment. I had to fix everything so that I could become a better bowler," said Tyagi.

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Rajasthan Royals	3	3	0	0	6	2.403
Punjab Kings	3	2	0	1	5	0.637
Royal Challengers	2	2	0	0	4	2.501
Delhi Capitals	3	2	1	0	4	0.811
Sunrisers Hyderabad	3	1	2	0	2	0.275
Gujarat Titans	3	1	2	0	2	-0.270
Lucknow Super Giants	2	1	1	0	2	-0.542
Mumbai Indians	3	1	2	0	2	-0.715
Kolkata Knight Riders	3	0	2	1	1	-1.964
Chennai Super Kings	3	0	3	0	0	-2.517



Charged up: Shami will look to extend his good run. R.V. MOORTHY

'Shami still trying to develop new skills'

Y.B. Sarangi
KOLKATA

Lucknow Super Giants spin-bowling coach Carl Crowe hailed seasoned pacer Mohammed Shami for his keenness to learn and improve.

Citing how Shami prepared with fast-bowling coach Bharat Arun to scalp dangerous Sunrisers Hyderabad opener Abhishek Sharma in LSG's last game, Crowe said, "Bharat and Shami worked on a new ball four days before the match, and Shami bowled that to dismiss Abhishek. "You're never too old to learn a new skill. It's testament to not only Bharat but also Shami's mindset that as a senior player, he's still willing to develop new skills and trying to push (improve) his game."

Ahead of LSG's Indian Premier League encounter against Kolkata Knight Rid-

ers at Eden Gardens here, Crowe praised Rishabh Pant for being a bowlers' captain.

"Pant definitely empowers his bowlers. He is someone who is very keen to hear their views in team meetings. He's interested to see what their perspective is and what their plans are. When he enters the room as captain, he says 'hello' to every single person, shakes their hands. It makes you feel like you're welcome and you belong there," Crowe added.

Crowe spoke enthusiastically about spinner Digvesh Rathi. "He has an exciting skillset. He's capable of playing for India in the future. When you're working with those types of players, what you want to do is guide them rather than restrict them. It's clear that his energy and passion drive his game," said Crowe.



Queen's gambit: Vaishali capitalised on Divya's errors to pull off a win. FIDE

Vaishali beats Divya, remains in joint lead

CANDIDATES CHESS

Sports Bureau

In an engrossing all-Indian battle featuring two of the overnight leaders, R. Vaishali outclassed an erratic Divya Deshmukh at the FIDE Women's Candidates chess tournament at Pegeia, Cyprus, on Wednesday. The Grandmaster from Chennai has thus retained her lead after the ninth round.

The day had begun with five women in the lead, but it is now down to just two. Zhu Jiner is the other player on 5.5 points, following her win against Kateryna Lagno.

Anna Muzychuk is just half-a-point behind them, followed by Divya and Lagno on 4.5.

Five rounds remain in the eight-player double round-robin league.

Divya ran into some serious problems after making two poor moves, back to back, with her rook and knight. This gave a clear advantage to Vaishali, who finished with a flourish

▼ The day had begun with five women in the lead, but it is now down to just two. Zhu Jiner is the other player on 5.5 points, following her win against Kateryna Lagno

through a superb exchange sacrifice. Black resigned immediately.

In the open section, Anish Giri stunned second seed Fabiano Caruana to climb to second with 5.5 points, 1.5 behind the runaway leader Javokhir Sindarov, who drew with Matthias Bluebaum.

R. Praggnanandhaa failed to convert his better position against Wei Yi and split the point.

The results: Open: Fabiano Caruana (USA) 4.5 lost to Anish Giri (Ned) 5.5; R. Praggnanandhaa 4 drew with Wei Yi (Chn) 4; Matthias Bluebaum (Ger) 4 drew with Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb) 7; Hikaru Nakamura (USA) 4 drew with Andrey Esipenko (Rus) 3. **Women:** Tan Zhongyi (Chn) 3 drew with Anna Muzychuk (Ukr) 5; Zhu Jiner (Chn) 5.5 bt Kateryna Lagno (Rus) 4.5; Aleksandra Goryachkina (Rus) 4 drew with Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz) 4; R. Vaishali 5.5 bt Divya Deshmukh 4.5.

India rebounds to beat NZ for first win in BJK Cup

Young talents Vaishnavi and Sahaja register facile victories before the experienced Ankita and Rutuja complete the formalities to bring the smiles back after the loss against Thailand

TENNIS

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

India rode on its young singles players to bounce back and win its second tie against New Zealand 3-0 to stay in contention for a top-two finish in the Billie Jean King Cup Asia/Oceania Group I and a spot in the Playoffs here on Wednesday despite rains threatening to play spoilsport.

After a disappointing 2-1 loss against Thailand in the opening tie that stretched across two days due to inclement weather, Vaishnavi Adkar and Sahaja Yamalapalli fought back, the latter within hours of her opening match, to give India a 2-0 lead at the DLTA Complex.

The experienced pair of Ankita Raina and Rutuja Bhosale then completed the formalities with a 6-4, 6-2 win against the fancied pair of Erin Routliffe and Monique Barry to be third on the table.

Taking charge Vaishnavi, who was all over the place in the opening match on Tuesday, was far more in control of her shots and won 6-2, 6-4 against Aishi Das.

Clearly superior to her 18-year-old opponent ranked more than 700 places behind, Vaishnavi dominated with a more as-



Opening salvo: Vaishnavi's straight-set win put India on the road to victory. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

sured presence, relying on her accuracy and Aishi's inconsistency to race to a 6-2 win in the first set.

With the sun shining through, Vaishnavi was able to control the ball's speed much better and broke Aishi in the opening game, then in the fifth and seventh games to take the set. Aishi put up an improved performance in the second, fighting back from being 4-1 down to level 4-4 but Vaishnavi quickly regained control and served out the match when Aishi hit wide.

Sahaja, who only had 5.5 hours between her two matches, showed no signs of fatigue against Valentina Ivanov in her 6-1, 6-3 win in

one hour 25 minutes.

Intelligently mixing her strokes and pushing Valentina hard to earn every point across the court, Sahaja added soft drops and volleys to her powerful returns from the baseline to stay in control.

Earlier, in the morning, India lost the opening tie against Thailand 2-1 after Patcharin Cheapchandej won her overnight match against Sahaja 6-4, 1-6, 6-4.

Ankita and Rutuja completed a consolation win against Thasaporn Naklo and Peangtarn Plipuech 6-3, 6-4.

In the other unfinished encounter from Tuesday, New Zealand's Monique Barry and Erin Routliffe

got the better of Priska Madelyn Nugroho and Aldila Sutjiadi 4-6, 6-0, [10-6] but Indonesia won 2-1.

The results: India bt New Zealand 3-0 [Vaishnavi Adkar bt Aishi Das 6-2, 6-4; Sahaja Yamalapalli bt Valentina Ivanov 6-1, 6-3; Rutuja Bhosale & Ankita Raina bt Monique Barry & Erin Routliffe 6-4, 6-2].

Indonesia bt Mongolia 3-0 [Aldila Sutjiadi bt Anu-Vjin Gantor 6-0, 6-0; Anjali Kirana Junarto bt Khongorzul Aldarkhishig 6-2, 6-0; Anjali & Meydiana Laviola Reinnamah bt Jargal Altansarnai & Oyungerel Khasbaatar 6-0, 6-0].

Korea bt Thailand 3-0 [Dayeon Back bt Anchisa Chanta 6-3, 6-4; Sohyun Park bt Patcharin Cheapchandej 6-4, 6-1; Dayeon & Eunhye Lee bt Thasaporn Naklo & Kamonwan Yodpetch 6-4, 7-6(4)].



All green and ready: Precision will be at a premium with no rain in the forecast to soften the course. GETTY IMAGES

McIlroy chases Masters repeat at lightning-fast Augusta National

GOLF

Agence France-Presse
AUGUSTA

Rory McIlroy seeks a historic repeat victory starting Thursday at the 90th Masters, while World No. 1 Scottie Scheffler and Bryson DeChambeau lead a host of challengers in firm and fast conditions.

Second-ranked McIlroy completed a career Grand Slam by capturing the green jacket at Augusta National last year, but only Jack Nicklaus, Nick Faldo and Tiger Woods have won back-to-back green jackets, Woods the most recent in 2001-2002.

"Maybe not the largest field in golf but it's the strongest," McIlroy said. "I know I can do it now, so that should make it a little easier for me to go out and play the golf I want to play."

McIlroy suffered an injury scare last month when back pain prompted his withdrawal at Bay Hill. But he competed the following week and has rested since.

Scheffler, last year's British Open and PGA Cham-

pionship winner, has failed in two Masters repeat bids.

"Defending can always be difficult, but I think that's mostly just the odds of winning a tournament in back-to-back years," Scheffler said. "That's just extremely challenging, especially when you look at major championships."

DeChambeau, who edged McIlroy for the 2024 US Open title, was in the final Sunday group last year at the Masters when the Northern Ireland star made history. "It's great if we can continue to have a rivalry," DeChambeau said.

Precision will be at a premium with no rain in the forecast to soften the course. Dustin Johnson, the 2020 Masters champion who holds the 72-hole Masters record score of 20-under par 268, is already seeing strong bounces on the course. Other contenders include world No. 3 Cameron Young, who won The Players Championship last month; England's Tommy Fleetwood, last year's Tour Championship winner, and England's Justin Rose, last year's Masters runner-up.

CENTRAL RAILWAY
PROVIDING PROJECT SUPERVISION SERVICES
Tender Notice No. DR.N.C.S&T. Tender.2026.02, Date: 07.04.2026. Name of work with its location: APPOINTMENT OF PROJECT SUPERVISION SERVICES AGENCY (PSSA) for PROVIDING PROJECT SUPERVISION SERVICES at Various Construction Sites / Sections in the Jurisdiction of Dr. CST/E/ Construction / Dadar / CR. Approximate cost of work: ₹ 2,70,93,888.24. Earnest money to be deposited: ₹ 5,41,900/- Date & time for closing of tender: 27.04.2026 at 15:00 Hrs. Date & time for opening of tender: 27.04.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. Website particular and Notice Board location where complete details can be seen: Website www.ireps.gov.in and office of Dy. Chief Signal & Telecom Engineer, (Construction), Central Railway, Near Tilak Bridge, Dadar, Mumbai- 400 028. Corrigendum (if any) shall be published on Website only. AK-31
Unauthorized crossing of railway line is a punishable offense

ENGINEERING AND OTHER ANCILLARY WORK
Tender Notice No.: 06 of 2026, Dated: 07-04-2026; E-Tender are invited by the undersigned for the following work: Tender No.: SRDENGHY-06-2026; Name of Work: Construction of passenger amenities building, one number distributed E.I Cabin, three numbers E.I. LOC Huts, SR.CDO office complex (80mx8m), new parcel office (100x8) Sqm. and provision of 46 bay shed for passenger, parcel platform and extension of existing platforms along with provision of new platform and other ancillary works at Guwahati railway station in connection with Guwahati Yard remodeling work (Re-Tender). Tender Value: ₹62,69,21,159.58; Earnest Money: ₹1,25,38,500/-; Date & time of closing/opening of tender at 13:00 hrs. on 07-05-2026. For complete information please visit in website www.ireps.gov.in
Sr. DEN, Guwahati
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile

Civil Aviation Department
Airport Road, Patna – 800014
Corrigendum -01
(PR.27249 (CAD) 2025-26)
Letter: No: याचनंनितो (सोजना) 09-17 / 2025 – 461/Patna,
Subject: Corrigendum for "Air Services to New International Destinations " – Regarding
This Corrigendum is being issued in light of the suggestions received during the Pre-Bid meeting held on 07.04.2026. The following amendments/clarifications are hereby made in the tender document published via letter No.-406 Dt. 25.03.2026 :
1. Amendment in Clause 20(a) (Exit From the Scheme Clause):
In addition to the existing provisions in the tender:
While the Client reserves the right, at its sole discretion, to withdraw financial support/operations by giving 30 days prior notice, the same right shall also be extended to the Service Provider (Airline Company), subject to giving 30 days advance notice.
2. Amendment in Clause 12.7(e) (Monitoring and Compliance):
In addition to the existing provisions in the tender:
If an airline bids to operate flights for more than 2 (2) days per week but fewer than seven (7) days per week, Viability Gap Funding (VGF) may be extended on a pro-rata basis, subject to a maximum limit equivalent to seven (7) days of operations per week.
3. All other terms and conditions of the tender shall remain unchanged.
Note : For details of tender and corrigendum, kindly visit the website; www.state.bihar.gov.in/cad
PR- 000582 (Civil Aviation) 2026-27
उक्त सूचना state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar से प्राप्त की जा सकती है।
नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।
Secretary
Civil Aviation Department

CENTRAL RAILWAY
CTRB BEARING
Dy. Chief Material Manager (CWE), C & W Workshop Matunga, Mumbai-400019. Tender Notice No: CWE/MTN/85265499/2026 due on 08-May-2026. Tender Title: CTRB Bearing for VB/Train set to TIMKEN Drg No.E59773 to CTRB OEM's drawing that has been approved/cleared by RDSO for the subject item. OEMs quoting with their drawing(s) should enclose RDSO's approval/clearance along with the offer. Special Condition: SUITABLE PACKING TO BE DONE TO AVOID DAMAGE DURING TRANSIT UNLOADING AND RUST PREVENTION DURING STORAGE. Firm's offer: same as above with CTRB Bearing for VB/Train set to Timken Drg. no. E59773 & Timken part no. NP737217FSA-90020. Qty: 704 Nos. Due Date: 08-May-2026. Value: 23442369. AK-26
Unauthorized crossing of railway line is a punishable offense

BENGALURU CENTRAL CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer (MPED & Transport), Ground Floor, Annexure-2 Building, NR Square, Bengaluru-560 002. Email Id: eemped.bbmp@gmail.com
No: EE(MPED&Transport)/TEND/01/2026-27 Date: 08.04.2026
INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (Through GOK KPPP Only) (Two Cover System)
The Executive Engineer (MPED&Transport) on behalf of the Commissioner, Bengaluru Central City Corporation (BCCC), invites Proposals (Technical and Financial) for appointing eligible reputed Service Providers for the services as given below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Project / Amount put to Tender (Rs. In Lakhs / Rupees) / EMD amount in Rs.
1	Providing Plumber, Carpenter and other Unskilled Labours to Bengaluru Central City Corporation office in GBA HO premises & PUB Building at MG Road mayohall, Bengaluru. Amount put to Tender Rs. 21,51,368.61, EMD Rs.50,000/-.
2	Providing Housekeeping Services to PUB Building Complex at MG Road Mayohall Bengaluru. Amount put to Tender Rs. 99,96,836.83, EMD Rs.1,50,000/-.

Calendar of Events :
(1) Availability of IFT/RFP Document in KPP portal:09.04.2026 onwards. (2) Last date for receipt of queries is 13.04.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs in the through KPP Portal. (3) Date of Pre bid meeting at The Office of Executive Engineer(MPED& Transport)BCCC : 15.04.2026@ 15:00 hours. (5) Date of Opening of Technical Proposals: 18.04.2026 after 16.30 hours. (6) Opening of Financial Proposal will be intimated to the Tenderers through mail/Phone.
Sd/- Executive Engineer (MPED & Transport), BCCC

National Highways Authority of India
(Ministry of Road Transport & Highways)
भर्ती सूचना / RECRUITMENT NOTICE
भारत सरकार, पदोन्नति / प्रतिनियुक्ति आधार पर निम्नलिखित पद के लिए भर्ती हेतु आवेदन आमंत्रित करता है:-
NHAI invites applications for recruitment to the following post on Promotion / Deputation basis:-

Post	No.	Pay Scale
मुख्य महाप्रबंधक (वित्त एवं लेखा) Chief General Manager (Finance & Accounts)	01	पे मैट्रिक्स में लेवल-14 (रु 144200-218200) Level-14 in the Pay Matrix (Rs. 144200-218200)

2. भारा.रा.प्र. की वेबसाइट (https://www.nhai.gov.in) पर उपलब्ध विस्तृत विज्ञापन में दी गई प्रक्रिया के अनुसार आवेदन दिनांक 08.05.2026 (सारा 06:00 बजे तक) ऑनलाइन आवेदन जमा करना सुनिश्चित करें।
The applicant is required to ensure submission of online application as per the procedure indicated in the detailed advertisement, available on NHAI website (https://www.nhai.gov.in), by 08.05.2026 (upto 06:00 PM).
3. आयु सीमा, योग्यता मानदंड, अन्य शर्तों और से संबंधित विस्तृत विवरण भारा.रा.प्र. की वेबसाइट पर देखे जा सकते हैं।
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TENDER NOTICE No: S/2026/14 Date: 08.04.2026
The Principal Chief Material Manager, North Western Railway, Headquarter Jaipur, for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-tenders on www.ireps.gov.in site as follows.

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty	Unit	Due Date
1.	40261669	JUMPER PLUG ASSEMBLY	199	Nos	05-05-2026

CORRIGENDUM

S. No.	Tender No.	Nit No.	Description	TOD
1	37263041	S/2026/10 dt.19.03.2026	Yoke pin support Plate with wear plate	Existing Read as 04/05/2026 21/04/2026

Note (1) Interested tenderers may visit the website www.ireps.gov.in for Full details/Description/Specification/EMD / tender cost etc. All tenderers are requested to obtain digital signatures and get them registered on above site and quote electronically only. (2) For viewing and participating in other tenders such as open tender costing below Rs. 50 Lakh, limited tenders, special limited tenders and low value tenders, please visit www.ireps.gov.in. [502-AJ/26]
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Last date for E-bidding	28.04.2026 (02.00 PM)
Tender Fee	Nil
EMD Amount	Rs.3,34,000/-
Pre-Bid Meeting (Hybrid Mode)	17.04.2026 (11.00 AM)
Date & Time of Opening of Tender Documents	29.04.2026 (04.00 PM)

Sd/- DIRECTOR

BANARAS LOCOMOTIVE WORKS, VARANASI-221004
Tender Notice No. PCE/BLW/ET/Publish/2026-27/018RT2 Office of the PCE Date: 07/04/2026
E-TENDER
Dy. Chief Engineer, Banaras Locomotive Works, Varanasi on behalf of the President of India invites "Open" Tender through E-Tendering from the contractors. SN.: 1, Tender No.: BLW-WAT-ET-018RT2-25-26, Name of Work : Operation & maintenance of existing Automatic Chlorination Plants at various Pumps in BLW for drinking water treatment as per BIS for 5 Years. Tender Cost (Rs): Rs. 2,30,05,468.20, Earnest Money (Rs): Rs. 4,60,100.00, Time of Completion: 60 Months, Closing Date of Tender: 30/04/2026 at 15:00 PM, Date of Opening of Tender: 30/04/2026 at 15:30 PM, Special Notice: To see the detailed terms & conditions of tender and for submission of tender, please visit- "website: http://www.ireps.gov.in".
PRO/BLWC-01 Dy. Chief Engineer, f b i n /blwvaranasi" Website:- www.blw.indianrailways.gov.in"

SOUTHERN RAILWAY					
Divisional Office, Works Branch, Tiruchchirappalli.					
E Tender Notice No. TPJ/04 of 2026 Dt. 06.04.2026					
Divisional Railway Manager/Works Branch/Tiruchchirappalli Division, Tiruchchirappalli-1 for and on behalf of the President of India invites ONLINE tenders for the following works as per tender notice and Complete details are given in our e-tender portal www.ireps.gov.in					
Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of the Work	Approx. value of the work (Rs. in Lakhs)	Amount of EMD (in Rs.)	Completion period of work
1	TPJ-04-2026-01	Earth work in forming embankment, construction of station building, Passenger & goods platform, retaining wall, extension of bridges, approach road etc., at TRM station yard in VM-TPJ (mainline) section.	1791.60	3583200	12 Months
2	TPJ-04-2026-02	De-stressing of LWR track including ancillary work for welding at various Locations in Ss/DEN/East/Jurisdiction..	293.50	587000	8 Months
3	TPJ-04-2026-03	(i) Renovation of 18 AC cabins including washroom improvements and Improvements to toilets in Railway hospital/GOC and (ii) Construction of dining hall and kitchen, and Provision of cubicle arrangements, fly-proof mesh in hostel rooms, dining hall and kitchen at MDZT/TPJ.	247.06	494100	6 Months
4	TPJ-04-2026-04	Periodical cleaning of over head tanks and ground level reservoir and P.V.C. water tanks in SSE/Works/TPJ section for a period of two years.	15.55	31100	24 Months
5	TPJ-04-2026-05	Maintenance of water level monitoring system at bridge No.252 at Km.274/300-400 between Ariyalur and Sillakudi stations for a period of 18 months.	4.41	8800	18 Months
6	TPJ-04-2026-06	Construction of subway with Pre-Cast RCC Box at in lieu of Level crossing No.29 in VM-PDY section.	474.43	948900	9 Months
7	TPJ-04-2026-07	Replacing of Existing height Gauge with Standard RDSO type Height Gauge in ROB/RUB -22 Nos. at various locations in ADEN/TVR sub-division.	202.89	405800	6 Months
8	TPJ-04-2026-08	Provision of footpath slab and watering hydrant pipe line at Thiruvavur station yard and (ii) Recoupment of Monsoon reserve materials in ADEN/MV and ADEN/TJ sub-divisions	50.27	100600	6 Months
9	TPJ-04-2026-09	Providing housekeeping and hospitality services for officers Rest Houses at VLR and VRI stations for a period of two years.	36.47	73000	24 Months

Sl. No. 1-5: Tender closing date and time: 30.04.2026 at 15:00 Hrs
Sl. No. 6-9: Tender closing date and time: 04.05.2026 at 15:00 Hrs
Note: (i) It is the responsibility of the tenderer to check any Corrigendum issued for any correction or modifications uploaded subsequently in website, the same shall be taken into account while submitting tender.
(ii) Exemption from remitting Bid Security Amount (EMD):
The following categories of tenderers are only exempted from remitting Bid Security:
a) Any firm recognized by Department of Industrial Policy and Promotion (DIPP) as "Startups" shall be exempted from payment of bid Security.
b) Labour Co-operative Societies shall submit only 50% of Bid Security.
Tenderer should submit relevant documents along with his/their offer from remitting Bid Security. Non-submission of relevant documents, shall lead to summary rejection of offer.
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3	62	IIT Madras
4	64	IIT Kharagpur
5	86	IIT Kanpur
6	119	VIT
7	129	IISc Bangalore
8	141	IIT Roorkee
9	166	IIT Guwahati

Source: <https://www.topuniversities.com/universities/vellore-institute-technology-vit-vellore-india>

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- EEE (India Rank # 6)

Top 150

- Mathematics (India Rank # 5)
- Materials Sciences (India Rank # 7)
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There will be expectations, but I am focusing on my work

Representing Capitals in his maiden IPL, Nabi, who was the toast of the 2025-26 domestic season as J & K won the Ranji for the first time, will test himself in the world's biggest T20 league after he was roped in by the franchise for ₹8.4 crore; the medium-pacer from Baramulla opens up on the challenge ahead and the domestic season just gone by

INTERVIEW

Auqib Nabi

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

For the best part of two years now, Jammu & Kashmir's Auqib Nabi has compelled the domestic cricket landscape in India to take notice of his talent with eye-popping exploits in the First Class circuit. Thrust a new red ball into his right hand and Nabi, shy and reticent otherwise, invariably makes it talk, luring seasoned batters into his trap with subtle changes in his wrist position. For evidence, look no further than his dismissals of K.L. Rahul and Karun Nair in Karnataka's first innings of the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy final.

It is owing to this precious skill that Nabi has been at the vanguard of J&K's headline-grabbing performances recently. In an epochal 2025-26 Ranji season that witnessed the northern side break free from the shackles of history and lift the crown for the first time, Nabi's display – he effected 60 dismissals in 10 matches – was the piece de resistance. The medium-pacer pacer from Baramulla was no less influential in the preceding season, claiming 44 wickets in J&K's run to the quarters – it was a one-run first-innings deficit against Kerala that agonisingly hindered the Paras Dogra-led outfit from marching ahead. As irresistible as Nabi has been in India's



Nabi... on a sizzling run.
K. MURALI KUMAR



Mindset-wise, I was thinking a lot about results earlier. For the last 2-3 years, I have not been thinking about results. I have been concentrating on following my process. I have been positive

premier First Class competition, it is a sign of the times that a broader endorsement of his ability will readily come if he can cut it in the Indian Premier League over the next two months. His style may not be as suitable to the white-ball game, but he did scalp 15 wickets in seven games for J&K in the last Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy – the domestic T20 meet – at a creditable economy rate of 7.41 runs per over.

Having been acquired by Delhi Capitals for ₹8.4 crore in the mini-auction last December, the expectations are high from Nabi's maiden IPL season. Before the summer show-piece got underway, the 29-year-old sat down with the media over a Zoom call and responded to numerous queries about his first IPL gig and his stunning exploits for J&K. Edited excerpts:

You like setting up batters in First Class cricket. In T20s, the time to make an impact as a bowler is limited. What will you look to hold onto from the red-ball game in the shortest format?

My go-to plan, regardless of the format I'm playing in, is to keep things simple. I don't like to overthink and complicate things too much. That is my mindset.

In the past, you have been a net bowler in the IPL. How were those experiences?

I was a net bowler with 2-3 different franchises (Sunrisers Hyderabad, Gujarat Titans and Kolkata Knight Riders). Talking to international players and taking feedback on how to improve, it was a very good experience.

How are you planning to deal with the pressure of expectations in the IPL?

Obviously, there will be expectations. But I am focusing on my work, and not giving a lot of attention to the things that are being said. I am focusing more on my preparation and how I can do well in this format to help win matches for Delhi Capitals.

You have excelled in domestic cricket for J&K. This is your first IPL season. What will be the biggest difference between the other domestic competitions and IPL?

The margin of error is less in the IPL. Domestic cricket is also at a good level, but in the IPL, you won't expect to get away with a lot of mistakes. It is about the margin of error. That is the difference between the IPL and domestic cricket.

You are from Baramulla district in Kashmir. What were the challenges in the journey from there to the IPL?

Nothing was too difficult as such. It is just that we lacked infrastructure in J&K. There weren't good turf wickets in the region for training and preparation. Things are gradually getting better. I just had to use the limited facilities and resources to the best of my ability, and prepare accordingly.

Your IPL stint with Delhi Capitals



has been highly anticipated. Personally, what are your goals for this season?

My strength is that I swing the new ball. At the back end, in T20s, you need yorkers and slower balls. I am working on that with coaches. I won't veer away from my strengths and I will keep things simple. Whenever I play in any tournament, my goal is to finish as the highest wicket-taker. Hopefully, my contributions can help DC win the title.

If getting selected for India is the ultimate goal, how important is the IPL in fulfilling that desire?

It will be very important. The tournament is watched around the world. The competition is very good. For red-ball selection, I have performed well in domestic cricket. I am not thinking too much about India selection. I am doing the things that are in my control, and not focusing on external factors. Obviously, playing for India is the ultimate goal. It will be a dream-come-true. But for now, my focus is to do well in this IPL.

DC engaged in a bidding war and secured your services for ₹8.4 crore. What is your take on the price tag?

It wasn't about the money. I wanted to play once in the IPL, even if I got just ₹30 lakh. Obviously it felt good that



From the time I started playing professionally, I have tended to watch the videos of all bowlers, and observe how different bowlers operate in different conditions and situations

Delhi Capitals invested so much money. My strength is to swing the new ball both ways. My focus will be on doing that and getting wickets up front.

The price tag won't play on my mind. I just wanted to play at this level and prove that I am good enough. Pressure will be there, but I am not focusing on the outside noise.

What was the day of the IPL auction like? Can you recall the emotions you went through?

I was at home on the day of the auction. The camp for the Vijay Hazare Trophy was going to start on the next day. Everyone at home became emotional, because it has taken so many years of hard work. Everyone's dream was for me to play at a higher level. Looking at their reactions, I also became emotional. I hadn't told any of my friends or other people in the area that I was at home. But a crowd gathered outside my house, and everyone was dancing with joy. It felt good to witness all of that.

You are also known to hit a long ball with the bat in hand. How much focus are you placing on improving your batting?

I have always been working on my batting. I have been batting a lot in the nets since coming into this set-up, and talking with the coaches here on how I can make myself better. If I can contribute with the bat as well, it will be very good for myself and the team.

Reflecting on J&K's Ranji win, what sort of impact do you envisage it having on cricket in the region?

It will have a big impact. Earlier, other teams used to think they could beat J&K inside two days. Things have changed now. There weren't role models to look up to in the past because the results weren't coming. There were no trophies. Now, parents have begun supporting kids playing cricket because they can foresee a bright career in the sport. We've won the Ranji Trophy. There are guys from J&K playing in the IPL and for India. We are competing with the best teams in the country. So, it will have a positive impact. Infrastructure will also become good with time.

How has life changed for you since the IPL auction?

I have just been playing cricket regularly since the auction. I have expectations from myself that I have to do well at this level. I have been doing well till now. Everyone expects you to keep doing well. That is it. I can't see any changes as such.

You made your Ranji debut in January 2020, but it took you until the 2024-25 season to make a substantial impact. What changes did you make in the last two years?

There were things that I worked on with the coaches. Two-three years ago, the Jammu & Kashmir Cricket Association (JKCA) did not have a bowling coach for the team. You don't know what you are doing wrong when there is no (bowling) coach. The bowling coach can point out small things, and that can make a big difference. That has helped.

Mindset-wise, I was thinking a lot about results earlier. For the last 2-3 years, I have not been thinking about results. I have been concentrating on following my process. I have been positive and that has been the secret to my success.

What is the most challenging part of bowling in T20s?

I need to improve my death-bowling in T20s. That is something I need to focus on in the shortest format.

Is there any particular bowler that you idolise?

Growing up, I used to watch Dale Steyn a lot. I used to copy his bowling action. From the time I started playing professionally, I have tended to watch the videos of all bowlers, and observe how different bowlers operate in different conditions and situations. You get to learn from everyone.

You have been very complimentary of the role that J&K bowling coach P. Krishnakumar has played in your development. What are you looking to learn from DC bowling coach Munaf Patel?

In all the conversations we have had so far, Munaf bhai is very chill. He has just told me to continue doing what I have been doing to be successful. He wants me to not tweak things. He has told me to be positive. There hasn't been a lot of stress on technical aspects. I am very excited about working with him going forward too.

Before the auction, you attended DC's trials. Did you sense during the trials itself that you would get an opportunity to play in the IPL?

In the trials at DC, I spoke to all the coaches. They all had a positive response and told me that they were looking at me. If the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy went well, I felt I could get a chance in the IPL.

CM YK S CH-CHE

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Women borrowers' share of India's total credit in 2025

26 in per cent. Women borrowers in India hold a credit portfolio of ₹76 lakh crore as of 2025, according to a NITI Aayog report. It said that between December 2017 and 2025, the credit-active women borrowers registered a compounded annual growth rate of 9%. PTI

Decline in crude oil futures after ceasefire announcement

18 in per cent. Crude oil prices nosedived to ₹8,775 per barrel in futures trade on Wednesday, after the U.S. and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire. Crude oil futures for April delivery opened lower by 6% to ₹10,029 per barrel, its lower circuit limit, on the Multi-Commodity Exchange. PTI

Polling stations tagged as 'vulnerable' for Nagaland bypoll

13 Security has been tightened for the bypoll to the Koridang Assembly seat in Nagaland's Mokokchung district, with night curfew in force in four villages following an election-related violence that claimed one life. Six candidates are in the fray for Thursday's Assembly bypoll. PTI

Share of overutilised loco-pilots in Indian Railways in 2025-26

55 in per cent. A railway loco pilots' union claimed that 8.85% engine drivers worked for over 12 hours straight during 2025-26, while 46.96% were deployed for more than nine hours. As per railway norms, a loco pilot cannot be deployed for a shift longer than nine hours at a stretch. PTI

Cabinet-approved subsidy on P&K fertilizers for kharif

41,534 in ₹ crore. A meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved the subsidy rates effective from April 1 to September 30, 2026. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why India wants fast breeder reactors

How does a fast breeder reactor work? How is an FBR different from a PHWR? What is India's three-stage nuclear programme? Why are FBRs difficult to build and operate? How has India pursued fast breeder reactors? What happens after a reactor achieves criticality? What next for the PFBR?

EXPLAINER

Vasudevan Mukunth

The story so far:

In an important milestone, the prototype fast breeder reactor (PFBR) at Kalpakkam achieved criticality on April 6. The term 'criticality' is familiar to India: over the decades, it has been associated with the slow and tedious successes of India's nuclear power programme. At the same time, in keeping with many terms in the nuclear vocabulary, 'criticality' is also often mistaken as an end goal. In reality, it is actually the first step.

What is criticality?

A nuclear reactor becomes critical when its chain reaction is able to sustain itself. That is, when an atom's nucleus undergoes nuclear fission, it releases neutrons that trigger at least one more fission reaction in the surrounding nuclei. Reactor engineers ensure this happens by controlling the composition of the fuel (the material whose nuclei undergo fission), how well the neutrons are able to 'access' more nuclei, and the temperature of the reactor. Once a reactor is critical, it also means it is in a kind of stable state. However, it does not mean that it is operating in a commercially viable way. That comes much later. After criticality, the operators keep the reactor running as it produces a low amount of power, for months if necessary, while they check if its operating parameters are within design limits. If an operator is sure that the parameters are, they can go to the next stage.

How do FBRs work?

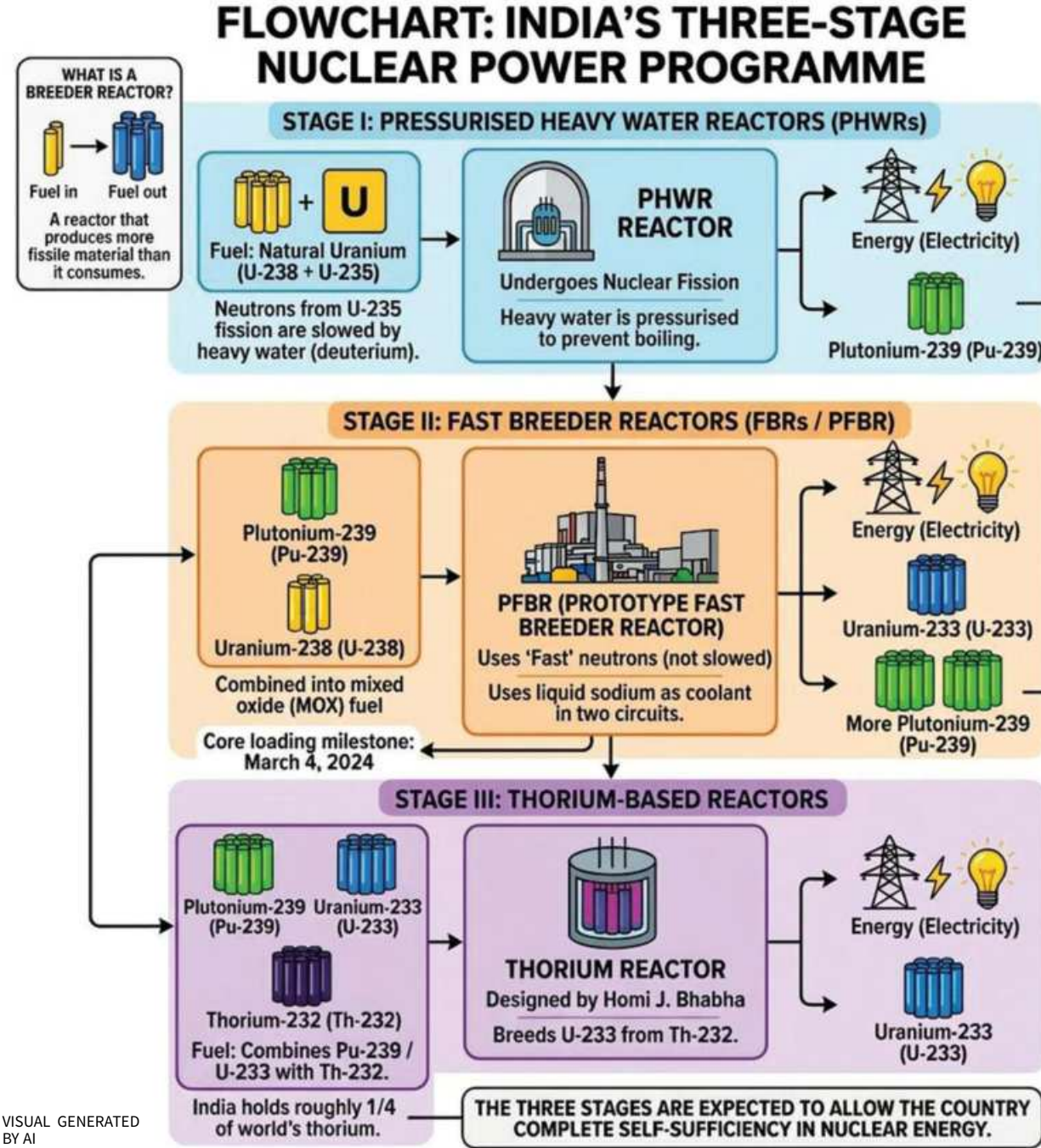
Most of India's currently operating nuclear reactors are pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWRs). They are designed to support the fission of natural uranium. Natural uranium consists of 99.3% of uranium-238 and 0.7% of uranium-235. '235' and '238' denote the total number of protons and neutrons in the nucleus. In a PHWR, neutrons are introduced into the reactor, where a device called a moderator slows them down. This is necessary for the neutrons to cause uranium-235 to undergo fission. When it does, it releases heat, which the PHWR converts to electricity; a small amount of plutonium; and a few neutrons.

PHWRs are inefficient because only a small fraction of the fuel, around 1%, undergoes fission before it becomes unusable.

A fast-breeder reactor (FBR) is more efficient, achieving a fuel use rate of around 10% or more. Mainly, the fuel consists of plutonium, not uranium. The reactor core is surrounded by a 'blanket' of depleted uranium, like the unusable fuel produced by PHWRs. When a fast neutron bombards the blanket, the uranium nuclei are transmuted to plutonium nuclei, which are reprocessed as nuclear fuel. The plutonium-based fuel also uses the fast neutrons to undergo fission, releasing more fast neutrons.

What is India's three-stage programme?

The nuclear physicist Homi Bhabha is widely credited with conceiving India's nuclear programme in the first years of its independence. The programme has three stages. In the first stage, PHWRs will use natural uranium to produce plutonium and depleted uranium and electricity. In the second stage, FBRs will use the plutonium and depleted uranium from the first stage to produce even more plutonium and electricity. Finally, future



THE GIST

PFBR at Kalpakkam achieved criticality, the first step in a sustained chain reaction, but commercial operation remains pending.

Fast breeder reactors use plutonium and depleted uranium to produce more fuel, forming a bridge in India's three-stage nuclear programme aimed at long-term fuel security.

Despite being technically feasible, FBRs face high costs, operational complexity, and delays, making their economic viability and wider acceptance uncertain.

nuclear reactors will use plutonium and thorium to produce electricity.

Bhabha came up with this programme because India has abundant quantities of thorium but only modest reserves of uranium.

And in this scheme, FBRs have been envisaged as a bridge between the initial step, to use what we have, and the final step, to complete the cycle and thus make India self-sufficient in nuclear power.

Why are FBRs challenging?

That an FBR is easier said than done would be a gross underestimate. The Indian government approved the PFBR more than two decades ago. It was designed by the Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research and built by the Bharatiya Nabhikiya Vidyut Nigam, Ltd. The latter proved to be more challenging than first expected.

Among other features, the PFBR uses liquid sodium as coolant. Sodium becomes liquid at a higher temperature, and at higher temperature heat transfer is more efficient. Liquid sodium also does not need to be pressurised. However, it reacts violently with air and water, so the pumps, pipes, and tanks exposed to liquid sodium need to be perfectly sealed, with stringent leak detection protocols. Water-cooled reactors do not have such operational complexities, nor the additional cost.

India is also not alone in confronting these challenges. Japan's Monju Nuclear Power Plant suffered a sodium leak and fire in 1995, leading to long shutdowns; the plant eventually had to be decommissioned. The Superphénix in France was once the world's largest

breeder reactor but it was shut down as well, due to technical issues and high operating costs, which also fanned political opposition. Russia, however, has continued to maintain a small fleet of fast-breeder reactors.

In other words, operators have shown FBRs to be technically feasible but they are not yet economically feasible; they have also not won broader public acceptance. Aside from the costs of making them, they also demand rigorous oversight – which depends on both engineering excellence and the safety culture.

How has India pursued FBRs?

India is pursuing FBRs because, as discussed earlier, the three-stage nuclear programme prioritises long-term fuel security. Importantly, it is able to do so because India's nuclear sector remains largely driven by the state. Its decision-making structure is relatively insulated from the ruling establishment: the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE) reports directly to the Prime Minister's Office. As a result, as long as there has been political stability, India has been able to sustain nuclear projects across electoral cycles.

On the flip side, this insulation has reduced scrutiny of the nuclear power programme and protected it from the same pressure to deliver that assails other public sector enterprises like the Indian Railways and the National Highways Authority of India. Engineers have taken on projects with limited transparency on timelines and budgets. When one or both have slipped, the accountability has been spread across agencies. The PFBR's

original cost was ₹3,500 crore. It came to ₹6,800 crore in 2019. The DAE also sought multiple deadline extensions. In 2020, it said the PFBR would be commercialised in October 2022. That milestone is still pending.

The economics of FBRs also remain uncertain. In addition to the aforementioned issues, the broader fuel cycle – especially the reprocessing of spent fuel and the fabrication of new fuel assemblies – will require its own infrastructure. And for this the nuclear establishment will have to set up new regulatory processes.

What next for the PFBR?

The PFBR will be operated at a low power level to check its behaviour in different operating conditions. Engineers will collect the data from these tests to inform decisions about raising the reactor's power output and refining safety protocols. Eventually, they will seek approval from the Atomic Energy Regulatory Board to operate the reactor in commercial mode.

This entails running the PFBR at or near its rated capacity to generate electricity for the grid on a sustained basis, with standard operating procedures and clear regulatory oversight. At this point in time, the reactor will also have transitioned from being experimental to a commercial power plant.

In parallel, the DAE will also develop fuel reprocessing facilities and plan for future FBRs. Once these aims are closer to being realised, the government and India will develop a clearer sense of whether the broader vision of a closed fuel cycle can be realised.

S CH-CHE